灯塔集
The Tall Lighthouse

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周期性挣扎
Periodical Suffering CH17703-01

Periodical Suffering
周期性挣扎

"I seem to have stood still for an eternity,"

"Engulfed by a sea of thoughts, kept silent as a cemetery."

"The three lighthouse keepers on the isles still remain,"

"Where they should have long passed into memory."
“我似乎伫立了很久”

“思绪万千，却一言未发”

“南岛上的三位水手仍然活着”

“那些本应早已逝去的人们”

Marcus: ...
马库斯: ……

Marcus: So much has transpired here upon the Flannan Isles, each and every event etching itself into my consciousness ...
马库斯: 弗兰南群岛上发生了太多太多的事，其中的每一幕都令我印象深刻，难以割舍……

Marcus: Despite all my installments so far on the History of the Flannan Isles, what I've documented barely scratches the surface ...
马库斯: 尽管《弗兰南群岛史》已经连载了好几期，但我所记录的甚至不到十分之一……

Marcus: The readers, I believe, share my eagerness for the next issue of the Daydream Post ...
马库斯: 读者们一定都像我一样，迫不及待地等着下一期的《白日梦邮报》……

Marcus: *deep breath* I cannot let them down.
马库斯: 呼……我不能辜负他们的期待。

Marcus: ...
马库斯: ……

Marcus: The young lady rubs her eyes and refocuses back to her writing.
马库斯: 年轻的姑娘揉了揉眼睛，将思绪重新浸入脖颈与帽檐之间的领地。

Marcus: The History of the Flannan Isles column has to fit in roughly a third of a page ... But there are so many more stories about the archipelago I've yet to tell—stories the readers still haven't heard ...
马库斯: 留给《群岛史》的版面大概还有三分之一张报纸……可这座岛上还有太多我没有提及的内容，它们说不定正是读者尚未了解的……

Marcus: Ms. Dennehy mentioned that even the editors have been following the mysteries of the Flannan Isles with intrigue ... If I can keep up that interest, she might allow me an additional section!
马库斯: 丹尼希女士曾说，连编辑们都对弗兰南群岛的谜团相当好奇……如果内容足够丰富，兴许她会允许我再补充一节！

Marcus: That way, I can present our readers with a more comprehensive look at their stories.
马库斯: 这样，人们就能完整地了解弗兰南群岛发生的一切了。

Livened up, she dives back into her writing.
她打起精神，又伏在了书案上。

Marcus: "The Flannan Isles, a small island chain in the Outer Hebrides of Scotland, have been the subject of rumor for years. Even up to today, many mysteries still remain here ..."
马库斯: “弗兰南群岛，位于苏格兰的外赫布里底群岛之中。关于它的讨论已持续了数年。直到今天，我们仍能记起关于它的传闻……”

Marcus: "Of course, to hear it from the credible authorities, the lighthouse and indeed, the whole archipelago, were perfectly normal, all except for ..."
马库斯: “据可靠消息称，不论是在灯塔内，抑或是岛上的任何一处角落，一切似乎都无比正常。”

Marcus: "... its three vanished lighthouse keepers."
马库斯: “除了那三位离奇消失的灯塔管理员……”

Marcus: "Speculation over their disappearance drove the public wild, yet the authorities claimed they were simply swept away in a deadly storm."
马库斯: “人们纷纷猜测其中的可能性。来自官方的调查员先生坚持认为，某场意外发生的海上风暴吞没了他们……”

Marcus: "This, of course, did nothing to convince them."
马库斯: “但这显然无法说服大多数人……”

Marcus: "Meanwhile, a sailor claimed to have seen coal-black UFOs over the islands, casting eerie, cold beams of light ..."
马库斯: “有水手声称，他在弗兰南群岛的上空目睹了来自太空的飞碟，它们通体黝黑，散发着幽深而寒冷的光束……”

Marcus: "Other theories included gargantuan man-eating birds, a bottomless abyss, and so on ..."
马库斯: “当然，关于巨型鸟类、无底深渊的猜测同样不少……”

Marcus: "Rumors continue to swirl, but the truth remains elusive ..."
马库斯: “人们众说纷纭，但始终没能得出答案……”

Marcus: "The police report, the log entries, and the lack of any recovered bodies ... They all scream one thing—this is no simple disappearance ..."
马库斯: “警察先生们出具的调查报告，守塔员们所遗留的日志记录，以及迟迟未能找到的尸体……它们提醒着我，这绝非一起简单的失踪事件……”

Marcus: "Twelve years have passed, yet driven by curiosity, I decided that I must visit the islands myself ... And there I discovered a never-before-seen log book."
马库斯: “尽管已过去了十二年，但怀着对真相的好奇，我仍然决定来到这座岛上……也见到了那份始终没有公开的记录。”

Marcus: "The signature on it reads 'James, recorded on December 15, 1900.'"
马库斯: “上面的落款是，1900 年 12 月 15 日 记录人：杜卡特。”

Marcus: ...
马库斯: ……

Marcus: Her pen hangs in mid-air, like a sail on still water, hesitating to embark on the next line.
马库斯: 握笔的手顿在了半空，如同无风的帆船，迟迟未能驶入下一行。

Marcus: So much time has passed since the incident, yet the mysteries only seem to multiply ...
马库斯: 这起事件已经过去了这么多年，关于岛上的谜团并没有减少，反而越来越多了……

Marcus: Hmm ... How can I sift through all these story threads?
马库斯: 我……该如何拣选这些素材呢?

Marcus: Before setting foot on the islands, I heard other unsettling rumors from the sailors. Ships passing too near often find themselves caught motionless on the sea, with eerie and unnatural ooze forming on their decks ... These frightful tales have meant that most give this archipelago a wide berth.
马库斯：当我尚未踏上这座岛时，我便听说了水手们的传闻。途径这儿的船只大多会无故抛锚，甲板上甚至会渗出古怪的液体……以致于这儿的航线远比其他岛更少。

Marcus: This is a story worth telling ...
马库斯：这是个值得一写的故事……

Marcus: Meanwhile ... there is the matter of the island's lighthouse, which has, through unknown means, been kept in operation for twelve years despite being abandoned.
马库斯：可……十二年都不曾中断的灯塔同样是个重大的问题。

Marcus: If I failed to include that sort of mystery in my History of the Flannan Isles, I'd surely regret it ...!
马库斯：如果没能将它记入《弗兰南群岛史》，我一定会抱憾终身……！

Marcus: Which, of course, leads to the central mystery of them all. The disappearance of the original lighthouse keepers in the first place ...
马库斯：当然，还有最重要的守塔员失踪事件……

Spoiled for choices, Marcus is, nonetheless, in a very briny pickle.
她陷入了迟疑。

An arduous choice lies before the poor girl.
残酷的、不留情面的选择题横亘在这个可怜姑娘的眼前。

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: History of the Flannan Isles belongs to the islands themselves. It's only fair that I treat their stories impartially ...
马库斯：《弗兰南群岛史》属于弗兰南群岛全体对象。出于公平起见，我也应该平等地使用它们……

Marcus: To turn down the opportunity to tell any of these stories feels like betraying the truth itself!
马库斯：无论放弃哪一个，都是对弗兰南群岛的背弃，是对这本书的误读！

Her gaze wanders, shifting from one page of notes to another.
她的目光游离，落在更多、更多的稿纸之上。

There it is, a narrow path that she could follow to capture the essence of all these stories.
一条足以容纳所有内容的路显现了出来。

Marcus: "I set the log book aside, noticing the lighthouse just as its light washes past me."
马库斯：“我放下了那本记录本，注意到身前这个仍然发着光亮的灯塔。”

Marcus: "After the disappearances, no one proved willing to station on the Flannan Isles ... The Eilean Mor lighthouse was left unmanned, or so it should have been."
马库斯：“在那段离奇的失踪案之后，再也没有新的管理员愿意驻扎在弗兰南群岛……艾琳·莫尔灯塔早已无人维护，至少本应如此。”

Marcus: "From the base of the lighthouse, I walk step by step upward. Curiously, I notice, the wooden stairway beneath my feet appears to be meticulously well-maintained, and stranger still is the warm yellow light spilling from the apex of the tower ..."
马库斯：“我站在灯塔的底下，逐级向上攀爬。出乎我意料的是，脚下的石阶，严丝合缝的绳结与螺丝，以及从塔顶向四周洒下暖黄色光亮的灯泡……”

Marcus: "They all silently, yet truthfully, convey an astonishing revelation: that this lighthouse has been running just as well as it had since it was abandoned twelve years ago!"
马库斯: “它们无声无息，却又诚实地向我传达着一个震撼了我许久的讯息：使那座灯塔得以正常运转的一切，都仍保存着十二年前的余光！”

Marcus: "My footsteps falter, nearly tumbling backward at the realization ... Yet, how could I believe all that I am seeing?"
马库斯: “我的脚步虚浮，几乎惊讶地向后仰翻……可我要怎么相信呢?”

Marcus: "Nevertheless, the slippery moss and weathered scratches adorning the grounds prove with cold logic that twelve years must indeed have passed here."
马库斯: “那些使我双脚打滑的苔藓与斑驳的划痕，毫不留情地向我证明着，这儿确确实实已经历经了整整十二年的时光。”

Marcus: "After composing myself, I decide to begin my exploration."
马库斯: “在短暂地平复心情后，我决定开始探索这儿。”

Marcus: "Just before I alighted, I sounded the ship's steam whistle to signal to passing vessels, if there were any. Then, I took the three remaining flares ..."
马库斯: “在此之前，我鸣响了船上的汽笛，以便途径这儿的船只能够注意到这儿。随后，我拿起了仅剩三支的信号弹……”

Marcus: "If misfortune befalls me, at least the maritime police can collect my body here within a week and have my story publicized, if that must be my last humble contribution to the world."
马库斯: “倘若我真的不幸遭遇了意外，凭借这个，海上警事至少能在一周之内来到这儿，收殓我的遗体，也能够将这本群岛史出版，以向世界证明我的贡献。”

Marcus: "Stepping back onto the island, I no longer feel as relaxed as before; a touch of fear and sorrow occupies me. But thankfully, my heart still harbors the courage to strive for knowledge and human progress ..."
马库斯: “再次踏上岛屿后，我的心情早已没有最初的惬意与闲适，些许恐惧与愁苦掩住了它们。但值得庆幸的是，我的心中仍然怀着为人类进步而努力的勇气……”

Marcus: "And to unveil the truth of this mysterious place."
马库斯: “以及揭开那片令人陌生的、神秘世界的真相。”

Marcus: "Door locks won't bar my way; I deftly climb through a window, entering into a cramped space that, by all rights, should have been long forgotten and moldering."
马库斯: “紧锁的房间无法阻挡我的脚步，我灵活地翻过了橱窗，爬进了这个理应早已无人问津的逼仄空间里。”

Marcus has fully immersed herself in the world she is recreating, wandering freely along the blank page, then back to the ink-stained words.
马库斯沉浸在自己唯一的世界里，在白纸上肆意漫步，在墨色的文字间徜徉。

Marcus: "The kitchen door is open, though there is naught inside. Not even a moldy apple, a rotten orange, nor even a cobweb."
马库斯: “厨房的门敞开着，里面空无一物，既无发霉的苹果或柑橘，也缺乏必要的蜘蛛网布景。”

Marcus: "My mind, as yet stiff with anticipation, suddenly and involuntarily relaxes as it stumbles over an idle thought."
马库斯: “我的大脑不由自主地放松了下来，一个更加显而易见，也更加令人轻松的想法从我的脑海中升起。”

Marcus: "Perhaps this was nothing more than a prank, if a poorly executed one."
马库斯: “这也许是一场失败的恶作剧，并且稍显拙劣。”

Marcus: "Or perhaps a kind-hearted soul, for the safety of all the ships in the area, made a habit of replacing the lighthouse's lamp and repairing its rusty screws, but bowed by some secret honor, swore to never tell any of his work ..."
马库斯：“兴许只是某个心血来潮的善良海员路过了这里，为了全体航船的安全，也为了自身的荣誉，他自发地更换了灯塔的灯源，处理了锈迹斑斑的老旧螺丝……”

Marcus: "These are, for now, my best theories on the nature of this mystery."
马库斯：“我如此想着。”

Marcus wields her pen with renewed fire, drowning out the sounds around her.
马库斯奋笔疾书，周遭的一切声响似乎都远远地消失了。

Marcus: "Out of obligation, I settled on making a final cursory check before leaving."
马库斯：“出于必要的环节考虑，我决定在离开之前做最后一次无关紧要的确认。”

Marcus: "To think it would mark the beginning of a whole new chapter of this unfolding mystery."
马库斯：“这是一场新悲剧的开始。”

Marcus: "Inexplicably, I found myself knocking on the bedroom door ... Stifling a chuckle, as I soon realized my folly."
马库斯：“我鬼使神差地敲响了卧室的门……当然，我很快便意识到了自己的愚蠢。”

"Knock-knock-knock!"
“咚咚——！”

Marcus: "But as I brace to push open the door, it swings open in spite of me with a grating creak."
马库斯：“而当我正准备用力推开那扇尘封的门时，它毫无征兆地打开了，挟着刺耳的嘎吱声。”

Marcus: "The sudden movement causes me to stagger and stumble, falling beside the fireplace inside the room."
马库斯：“突如其来的脱力使我踉跄地跌了进去，摔到了壁炉旁。”

Marcus: "To my surprise, the coal dust under my palms holds a comforting warmth, as if it had come from a dying flame, one that could again alight."
马库斯：“不慎擦在手中的煤灰并没有如预想般的冷硬，它们有着恰到好处的余温，似乎理所当然温暖着房内的所有人。”

Marcus: "Two figures form just beyond my vision, at first pale and translucent but gaining substance, as if to match my palpable fear."
马库斯：“两道由透明而逐渐变得清晰的身影映入我的眼帘，同时被映出的还有我强烈的恐惧。”

Marcus: "Are you ... ghosts?!"
马库斯：“你们是……幽灵?!”

Marcus: "The pair of specters suddenly shriek, as if in terror, 'You can see us?!'"
马库斯：“而这两位幽灵先生的惶恐并不亚于我，‘你能看见我们——?!’他们发出了尖锐的呐喊。”

Marcus: "And we face each other dumbfounded, before a series of knocks come from outside—steady and deliberate."
马库斯：“当我们面面相觑时，一阵不紧不慢的敲门声响了起来，来自门外——”

Marcus: "Knock-knock-knock!"
马库斯：“咚咚——！”

"Knock-knock-knock ..."
“咚咚咚——！咚咚——！”

Marcus: ...?!
马库斯：……?!

The knocking is no longer just a figment of the author's recollection.
突兀响起的敲门声似乎并不只是作者颅内的情绪渲染。

???: Ms. Marcus ...?
???: 马库斯女士……马库斯?

???: Anyone in there?
???: 你在里面吗——?

Marcus: Ah ... Yes. A moment please.
马库斯: 啊……是的，我在这儿。

She hurriedly gathers the papers now scattered across the desk, stacking them aside neatly.
她急急忙忙地收拢那些在桌面上躺得四仰八合的稿纸，将它们整齐地码在一旁。

Lest the voice outside had grown impatient, she cautiously pulls the door open.
在外面的声音变得更加不耐烦之前，门终于小心翼翼地被拉开一条缝。

Flannan Isles
弗兰南群岛

Investigator: Greetings, Ms. Marcus.
调查员: 你好，马库斯女士。

Investigator: The man before her, with his stern gray and neatly patterned tie, nods courteously.
调查员: 眼前这抹冷硬的灰白色与错落的格子礼貌地朝她点了点头。

Marcus: ... Greetings.
马库斯: ……您好。

Investigator: You'll see here I've been sent by the St. Pavlov Foundation. I am the investigator responsible for registering all arcanists in the Eilean Siar region.
调查员: 如你所见，我是圣洛夫基金会的调查员，负责埃利安锡尔区域的神秘学家登记与注册。

His tone is flat and official, but his bearing exudes an air of entitlement and pride.
他的语气淡漠，毫不遮掩地显露着他的骄傲，理所当然。

Marcus: The ... Foundation?
马库斯: 基、基金会……?

The significance behind that name has clearly been lost on the young lady.
遗憾的是，对方似乎并不能理解这个名字所代表的重要意义。

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

孤鸟或灰白犬
A Lone Bird, or a Gray Dog CH17703-02

A Lone Bird, or a Gray Dog
孤鸟或灰白犬

The two arcanists at the door exchange identical puzzled glances.
门前的两人面面相觑，惊疑不定的情绪迅速地泛滥开来。

The growing tension of the moment proves too much for the columnist to handle.
这场面显然令深入简出的专栏作者无法应付。

Marcus: Oh no ... Have I misspoken?
马库斯: 糟糕……我说错了什么吗?

Marcus: Was I so immersed in my writing that I neglected this gentleman's summons.
马库斯：一定是因为我太过沉浸在自己的世界里，怠慢了这位远道而来的先生。

Marcus: I don't recall how many times the door was knocked. Was it two? Three? Or five? No ... perhaps more than that, indeed.
马库斯：我甚至想不起来敲门声响起了多少次，二、三、五……不，也许更早。

Marcus: The sound of the door seems more muffled than usual. I should write Ms. Dennehy to see if she might buy me a doorbell, to send along with my fee.
马库斯：这扇门的质地并不好，声音也比普通的木门沉闷得多，或许我应该写信给丹尼希女士，请她取用一部分稿费，替我购置一盏门铃。

Marcus: But to travel all this way is nowhere near convenient. I doubt anyone besides the post would deliver here ...
马库斯：可是，到岛上来的路程并不方便，除了邮差先生，再没有人乐意到这儿来了……

Her thoughts wander further and further, only to be brought back by a deliberate and expectant cough.
她的思绪越飘越远，一声刻意的咳嗽将她扯了回来。

Investigator: Allow me to get straight to the point, Ms. Marcus.
调查员：直入正题吧，马库斯小姐。

Investigator: Our records show you've not left the Flannan Isles in some time.
调查员：根据我们的调查，你已经很久没有离开弗兰南群岛了。

Marcus: Y-Yes.
马库斯：是……是的。

Investigator: To be candid, this choice of accommodation has caused a bit of an inconvenience for our registrations.
调查员：坦白说，你的行动路径为我们的登记工作造成了不少困扰。

Investigator: Most arcanists, at the very least, will frequent a bare minimum of social events like the grand exhibitions or the festivals in Edinburgh ...
调查员：尚未登记的神秘学家大多出没于皇家博览会，或是爱丁堡艺术节之类的场所……

Investigator: Lady Nellie Melba's divine voice echoes in theaters from Europe to Australia, and if nothing else, the Highland Games attract thousands of spectators and participants every year.
调查员：内莉·梅尔巴爵士美妙的歌喉响彻在欧澳之间的大小剧院，高地运动会更是每年都能吸引数以万计的观众与运动员们投身其中。

Investigator: Somehow even the dreariest of my colleagues find time to celebrate these occasions, at least ... on occasion.
调查员：哪怕是我再愚钝的同僚，也愿意花上几天的时间为之庆祝。

Investigator: I mean to say, the world is filled with all kinds of wonders. And forgive my directness, Ms. Marcus, but you ought to consider seeing more of it. And I hesitate to mention ...
调查员：无数美好的象征都在这片土壤中发生着——恕我直言，马库斯小姐，你应该去更大的地方看看。

Marcus: I ...
马库斯：我……

The man's barrage of verbiage overwhelms the reclusive lady at the door.
接连不断的名词从夸夸其谈的口中涌出，令马库斯一阵头昏耳热。

Marcus: Perhaps this gentleman has caught some kind of mania, or ... have I really been isolated on this island too long and forgotten that people are all ... talkative like this?
马库斯：或许这位先生不慎感染了热病？还是我在岛上呆了太久，外面的人们都是如此的……健谈吗？

Marcus: Steady on, Marcus, you can handle this.
马库斯：冷静点，马库斯，你能应付好这一切的。

Fists clenched, she quietly cheers herself on.
她握紧拳头，小声地为自己打气。

Marcus: The current situation calls to mind a page of advice from Introduction to Social Etiquette ...
马库斯：目前的情况似乎能对应上《社交礼仪入门守则》上的建议……

Marcus: Rather than admitting their ignorance on a subject, a cultured person is wise to steer the conversation toward grounds more familiar to both parties.
马库斯：绅士们往往不会直接承认自己对于某个话题的无知，他们会巧妙地施展谈话技巧，将话题引导向双方都更熟悉的方向。

Marcus: And for this gentleman, a most suitable topic would be ...
马库斯：而对于这位先生，最适合的话题应该是……

Marcus: Ah, I have it!
马库斯：我明白了——！

Lifting her head, she realizes she must seize the opportunity to pierce through the man's blather.
她抬起头来，在对方滔滔不绝罗列的间隙，抓住了难得的救命稻草。

Marcus: Sir, I believe I heard a lot about your Foundation when I was in the orphanage.
马库斯：先生，我听说过您们。当我还在福利院的时候，听说了许多关于基金会的故事……

Marcus: That you were collecting ... arcanists, particularly children.
马库斯：你们似乎一直在收集神秘学家……尤其是孩子们。

Marcus: And that you did so by force.
马库斯：而从来不顾他们的个人意愿。

Investigator: ...?
调查员：……?

Marcus: Some children said people from the Foundation took away their friends ...
马库斯：孩子们都说，他们亲眼看见基金会的人抓走了他们的朋友……

The investigator's face grows somber. Evidently, their conversation had not been going as prescribed by Introduction to Social Etiquette.
她还想说些什么，对方的脸色逐渐晦暗。遗憾的是，这并不属于《社交礼仪》上所写的任何一种走向。

That much was clear, even to Marcus.
终于，这是马库斯能够读懂的“一页”了。

Investigator: That was a poor excuse for a joke, Ms. Marcus.
调查员：你一定是在开玩笑，马库斯女士。

Investigator: We are indeed living in a wondrous era, where transgressing social norms have become greatly valued: Rationality, science, freedom ... and, with it, of course, a "progressive" sense of humor.
调查员：这是个好时代，每一个人都很重视个人的进步。理性，科学，自由……当然，还有一点儿与潮流相匹配的幽默感。

Investigator: I am sure you only meant to appeal to that ... transgressive humor, but those accusations are quite inappropriate, even as a joke ...
调查员：尽管我能理解你过于进步的幽默感，但如此令人匪夷所思的藐视与污蔑仍是不适宜的。

Investigator: Especially as you haven't officially joined the Foundation yet.
调查员：——尤其是当你尚未办理完基金会的入职流程的时候。

Marcus: Oh no, no ... I don't mean to offend you. It happened in my home country, in Romania. Perhaps, things are different here.
马库斯：不不……这是在罗马尼亚发生的事，我想它与您和您同僚们的办事处无关。

Regrettably, there is nothing close to applicable in this scenario from her reading of Introduction to Social Etiquette.
很遗憾，书上的办法无法适用于所有的场景。

The heavier blow drops as Marcus at last picks up the man's intention in coming all this way.
但某些被无意忽略的话语显然对马库斯造成了更大的创伤。

Marcus: Wait a moment, sir ... Did you just mention something about ... joining the Foundation? Me?
马库斯：等等，调查员先生……您刚刚说的是，加入基金会?

Investigator: Naturally, is there a problem?
调查员：当然，这有什么问题吗?

He adjusts his lapels in both hands, as if launching into a well-practiced speech.
基金会职员：他理了理衣襟，像是在宣布一件稀松平常的人事任命。

Marcus: I-I ...
马库斯：我、我……我……

Investigator: Ms. Marcus, shall I take it your heart is beating so fast out of excitement?
调查员：马库斯小姐，你似乎有点心率过快?

Investigator: I understand how you feel; many new colleagues have experienced similar emotions. But please, don't worry, the Foundation has a full-fledged medical support system.
调查员：我理解你的狼狈，许多新同事都经历过类似的情况。但别担心，基金会拥有完备的医疗救助体系。

Marcus: Sir, would you stop for a moment ...
马库斯：调查员先生，请您停一停……

Her voice trembles as she speaks.
她终于找准机会，颤抖着张了张口。

Marcus: I very much appreciate your coming here. I've come to fully understand the importance of the Foundation and its popularity among other people, and ... well, of course, I'm grateful for your invitation ...
马库斯：多亏了您的帮助，我已经完全理解了基金会的重要性与它在人们之中的受欢迎程度，也非常感谢您的邀请……

Marcus: But as you can see, I currently have some unfinished tasks at hand, which are related to my ... dream.
马库斯：但如您所见，我现在手头上还有一些尚未完成的工作，它们关乎着我的……理想。

Marcus turns her gaze back, staring at the small corner behind the doorway—her world of writing.
马库斯回过头去，眼巴巴地望着门后那一方小小的写作天地。

Investigator: Oh, a dream! Well, might I ask what is your dream, Ms. Marcus?
调查员：噢，理想——！马库斯小姐，你的理想是什么?

The investigator nods knowingly, as if Marcus's response is not at all unexpected.
基金会职员：调查员老练地点了点头，似乎对此并不意外。

Marcus: I-I dream of making people aware of the mysteries of the Flannan Isles, and about the world of arcanum, and ...
马库斯：我、我希望能让更多人了解弗兰南群岛，能对神秘学世界不再陌生，能……

Investigator: Aye, well, that is indeed a great aspiration.
调查员：很远大的理想——

He steps forward, gesturing toward the boundless sea.
他顺势走上前来，朝着无边的大海扬起手。

Investigator: But, Ms. Marcus, don't confine yourself to just these islands! Look beyond the horizon. The world out there is full of mysteries waiting for us to explore and uncover.
调查员：马库斯小姐，别局限在这座岛！看看远方，看看这个伟大的世界，有多少神秘事件等着我们去探索，去发掘——

Investigator: And that is precisely what the Foundation aims to do!
调查员：这也正是基金会的理想！

Investigator: Surely, you wouldn't withhold your contribution to the welfare of humanity and the progress of civilization?
调查员：可别告诉我您不想为人类的福祉、为世界的进步献上一份力。

Marcus: No ... Indeed, this closely aligns with my goals. It's only that ...
马库斯：不……这确实和我的想法颇为相近。只是……

She pauses, swallowing the rest of her unfinished sentence.
她张了张嘴，把没说完的话咽了回去。

The investigator comes to some sudden realization as he scrutinizes the girl in the doorway.
对方仔细地打量了一番对方，像是猛然醒悟了什么。

Investigator: Oh! Of course, of course—you're a renowned writer, with countless readers awaiting your next piece ...
调查员：噢！当然，当然——您是一位知名的作家，一定有无数的读者们盼望着您接下来的精彩故事……

Marcus hurriedly waves her hand in denial, a noticeable flush spreading from her ears to her cheeks.
马库斯急忙摆了摆手，一抹显眼的红从耳根漫到了耳尖。

Marcus: No ... In fact, I-I'm really just a greenhorn columnist.
马库斯：不……我还只是个不成熟的专栏作者，还有许多需要改进的地方。

Investigator: Allow me to make my pitch again. The Foundation possesses a great multitude of literary works from all over the world, be they about humans or arcanists.
调查员：你可能还不清楚，基金会保存了世界上各地区的重要书目，不论是人类的，还是神秘学家的。

Investigator: Upon joining the Foundation, you need only to fill out a book request form, pending approval from our supervisors and administration, and then you can read our catalog to your heart's content.
调查员：加入基金会后，只需要填写查阅申请表格，通过相关负责人的审批，再顺利推进到行政复议阶段——你就能轻松地阅览它们。

Investigator: Joining the Foundation would more than serve any writer.
调查员：对于任何一位作家来说，基金会都应该是无法拒绝的选择。

Marcus: I ...
马库斯：我……

Marcus: But ... there are still so many people curious about the events that occurred here ... Stories I've yet to write ...
马库斯：只是……还有许多人都好奇着弗兰南群岛发生的故事……那些我还没来得及写下的故事……

Marcus: More importantly, James, Thomas, and Donald, my friends ... They're all counting on me to tell their stories about these islands.
马库斯：更重要的是，岛上的杜卡特先生、马歇尔先生、唐纳德先生……都期待着我能讲述更多关于他们的故事。

Marcus: My work here is not finished ...
马库斯：我的工作还没有结束……

She gasps, as if dislodging a boulder from her chest.
她大口喘着气，像是终于挤出了堵在胸口的磐石。

Investigator: ...
调查员：……

The man frowns, his disappointment evident beneath the polite exterior.
基金会职员：他皱了皱眉，毫不掩饰自己的失望。

Investigator: As you wish, Madam, I will faithfully report your choice to my superiors—
调查员：好吧，我会如实地将你的选择向上汇报——

Marcus: My choice ...?!
马库斯：选择……?!

She panics, again.
马库斯陷入了慌乱，又一次。

Marcus: No-no-no, I mean, I haven't made any choices yet ...
马库斯：不不不，我还没能做出决定……

Marcus: I only hope that you might give me some time to consider your proposal. I promise, it won't be long ...!
马库斯：我只是希望您能给我一些时间，请您相信我，这不会太久的……!

Whether moved by her nearly pleading tone, or swooping in on his pitch again, the investigator clears his throat.
近乎哀求的语气显著地打动了这位形式主义者的心。他郑重地清了清嗓子，大发慈悲地开口。

Investigator: As you wish, but I would caution you that the Foundation's enrollment capacity is limited.
调查员：好吧，但你得清楚，基金会的入职名额相当有限。

Investigator: Should you tarry too long in deciding, you may find yourself waiting outside our offices, wishing you'd taken up our offer sooner.
调查员：如果没赶上好时候，我想你得在办事处门口等上一段时间了。

Investigator: When you've made your mind up, send this to Eilean Siar—no need to write a specific address, just "The Foundation" will do.
调查员：如果你决定好了，就将信件寄到埃利安锡尔——不用写具体的地址，写上基金会就好。

He hands Marcus a letter with a checkered pattern, then turns abruptly without looking back.
对方将一封印有灰白格子的信件塞到了马库斯手里，头也不回地离开了。

Left alone, the girl sways and collapses to the ground.
留在原地的人身形摇摇欲坠，终于瘫坐在地。

The blank form is clenched tightly in her hand, creased with worries.
那封空白的信件被紧紧地攥在手里，徒增无数烦恼的褶皱。

Marcus: The Foundation is a renowned organization, one that possesses a significant number of arcanists like me. It might be a source of insights for my future work ...
马库斯：基金会的名气很高，他们之间有许多像我这样的神秘学家，这能为我的取材带来许多的帮助……

Marcus: Not to mention the Foundation's colossal collection of books both on arcanum and human society!
马库斯：调查员先生说得不错，想必基金会中有更多介绍神秘学的书籍……当然，人类相关的书目肯定也不在少数！

Marcus: Still, I have to think about my readers. They'll be waiting for the latest stories from the Flannan Isles ...
马库斯：可《白日梦邮报》的读者们同样在期待着我，期待着弗兰南群岛的故事……

Marcus: Not to forget that Ms. Dennehy holds great expectations concerning my work ...
马库斯：丹尼希女士也对我的文章寄予厚望……如果贸然离开，我一定会令更多人失望……

Marcus: How could I disappoint them ...?
马库斯：目前的《弗兰南群岛史》也吸引了不少人的关注，他们想必对神秘学现象也颇感兴趣……

Marcus: Ah ... Won't anyone help me with this ... conundrum?
马库斯：啊……有人能救救我吗?

Her faint cry fails to travel far.
微弱的呼救声并未传出太远。

It fails even to drown out the sound of renewed knocking.
甚至没能盖过一旁又再响起的敲门声。

"Knock-knock-knock ..."
“咚咚——！咚咚——！”

Marcus: ...?
马库斯：……?

Thomas: Ahoy, Ms. Marcus, you're finally awake!
马歇尔：嘿，马库斯——！你终于醒过来了！

Thomas: We thought we might find you sleeping outside again—for the thirteenth time!
马歇尔：我们还以为你又睡在了门外呢——第十三次！

Donald: And ... with your eyes still open.
唐纳德：而且……你、还是睁着眼睛的。

Another voice adds to chorus of cooing over Marcus.
另一道声音适时地为马库斯的现状作了更进一步的补充。

James: Ach, nothing unusual, is it, boys? Our wee Marcus has always been good at sticking her nose around looking for things she can umm, what d'ya call it again? Aye, "read"!
杜卡特：很正常，伙计们……我们的小马库斯擅长这个，把自己整个都塞进那些四四方方的匣子里，是叫什么来着……噢，“阅读”！

Marcus: Oh, hello, Mr. Thomas, Mr. Donald, and Mr. James.
马库斯：啊、你们好，马歇尔先生、唐纳德先生……还有杜卡特先生。

Thomas: You break our poor ghostly hearts, Miss. Did you nae hear our footsteps rushing over to you?!
马歇尔：真让人伤心，马库斯，难道你没有听见我们赶过来的脚步声吗?!

Marcus gives a quick glance at the three men's feet, which are nearly transparent, and hovering slightly off the ground.
眼角的余光悄悄地瞥了瞥对方三人漂浮在半空、近乎透明的双脚。

Marcus: ... I'm sorry.
马库斯：……我很抱歉，先生们。

Thomas: Right. No time for beating 'round the bush, cuddies. Give the letter on over to the lass. I'll bet it's another admirer heaping praise on our Marcus!
马歇尔：别再卖关子了，老杜卡特，快把那封信给马库斯——这说不准又是读者们寄过来的信，他们又该把马库斯夸得天花乱坠啦～

Another letter is handed to Marcus. Bearing a pattern familiar to her.
又一封信件被递到了马库斯的眼前，上面印着她更加熟悉的图案。

Thomas: Dinnae worry, Ms. Marcus. We were good, just as we promised. We remember the tongue-lashing you gave us when that last postman took a tumble into the water from fright ...
马歇尔：放心吧，马库斯。我们遵守了和你的约定，在上次的那位邮差先生从船上跌进水里、变成落汤鸡之后……

Thomas: We were quiet as church mice round the postmen lately—Eh, Donald? He can attest to it, what with him always hiding at a distance like a right coward.
马歇尔：我们就再也没有出现在任何一位新邮差的面前了——胆小鬼唐纳德可以作证！

Donald: Dinnae call me a coward! But aye. I promise you, Thomas hasn't spooked 'em, nary a bad face nor wink this time. Still, the postman turned tail the second he tossed down the letter ...
唐纳德：我……他们没有吓到我～马歇尔也没有朝着他们做鬼脸……但那些邮差们还是离得远远的，把信扔下就走了……

Donald: And just what are they so afraid of, anyway?
唐纳德：他们在害怕什么吗……？

James: This place, I'd reckon ... And that's why we need our wee Marcus and her History of the Flannan Isles to tell our story ...
杜卡特：人们当然害怕这儿，他们对这儿几乎一无所知……正因如此，我们需要《弗兰南群岛史》，需要借它来解除外界的人对我们的偏见……

James: That's exactly what our wee Marcus is trying to do.
杜卡特：这正是我们的小马库斯的努力成果！

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

James: What's wrong, Ms. Marcus? You seem ... a mite troubled.
杜卡特：怎么了，小马库斯……你看上去可不太高兴？

James: Something odd about that envelope?
杜卡特：信封上沾了什么奇怪的东西吗？

Marcus: It's ...
马库斯：这……

Marcus: It's ... a rejection for my fifteenth edition of History of the Flannan Isles.
马库斯：……这是《弗兰南群岛史》第十五节的退稿信。

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

三面岛屿
Three Islands CH17703-03

Three Islands
三面岛屿

The rejection letter shakes in her trembling hands.
拆出的信纸在一双不住颤抖的手上轻轻地摇晃着。

Marcus: "We regret to inform you ..."
马库斯: “我们很遗憾地通知您，马库斯女士……”

Marcus: "That after discussion by the editorial board, we will be unable to publish the fifteenth edition of your History of the Flannan Isles."
马库斯: “经过编辑审议会的讨论，我们暂时不能发表您的《弗兰南群岛史》第十五节。”

Marcus: "We would like to share with you our primary concern regarding this edition."
马库斯: “原因如下……”

Marcus: "Since its publication, History of the Flannan Isles has garnered intense discussion among our readers."
马库斯: “您的《弗兰南群岛史》一经发表，便收获了许多读者的热切讨论。”

Marcus: "We are well aware of their curiosity about the mysterious archipelago and of your skillful writing."
马库斯: “我们深知读者们对于这座神秘小岛的好奇，也清楚地相信您对于纪实作品的写作能力。”

Marcus: "It is in this hope that we ask you to revise your latest edition, to reveal the truth about the three lighthouse keepers in greater detail."
马库斯: “正因如此，我们希望您能修改《弗兰南群岛史》的新一节内容。相比现有的内容，我们希望您能揭露真相——关于三位守塔员更详细的信息。”

Marcus: "It cannot be understated that we are by no means doubting your capabilities, Ms. Marcus, but with their limited understanding of arcanum, most of our readers have expressed that they are more interested in what happened to the lighthouse keepers—the truth."
马库斯: “请别误会，马库斯女士。我们并非对您现有的记录有所怀疑，但我们的读者对于神秘学的了解尚且不足，他们非常关心守塔员们的过往，关心真相。”

Marcus: "They believe that you can unveil this mystery that has puzzled us for more than a decade and come to a tidy end for this story."
马库斯: “他们坚信，您一定能揭开困扰我们十余年的谜团，为这个耸人听闻的传说画上一个圆满的句号。”

Marcus: "In light of our decision, we have already reserved some promotional space for History of the Flannan Isles. We look forward to your revised edition."
马库斯: “针对当前的情况，我们已为您的《弗兰南群岛史》提前预留了一部分宣传版面。”

Marcus: "Yours faithfully, Dennehy."
马库斯: “——盼望着您新内容的，丹尼希”。

The letter floats to the ground, falling from a trembling hand.
这张信纸终于飘飘然落在了地上。

The girl lowers her head, devastation lingering over her.
遭受挫败的女孩低下了头，一阵酸楚涌了上来。

Marcus: Ms. Dennehy says she is unsatisfied with the latest edition ... But aren't these stories all a part of uncovering the truth our readers are expecting?
马库斯: 丹尼希女士似乎并不满意现在的故事……可是，这些故事不正是读者所期望的真实么?

Marcus: The oddly arranged reef, the ultimate cause of the lighthouse's phenomena ... Aren't the readers curious at all?
马库斯：那些排列古怪的礁石，灯塔怪象的成因……他们一点儿也不好奇么？

Marcus: The truth ... About what happened to the lighthouse keepers ... Did I do something wrong?
马库斯：揭露真相……守塔员的过往……是我弄错了么？

Marcus looks out at the ghosts gathered around her.
马库斯苦涩地望着凑在跟前的守塔幽灵们。

Marcus: It seems what the readers are really eager to learn about is not the isles but your legend ...
马库斯：读者们似乎并不希望了解这座岛，他们只是迫切地想要知道关于你们的传闻……

The elder ghost pats Marcus on the shoulder.
年长的幽灵拍了拍马库斯的肩头。

James: It's not your fault, wee Marcus. You'd think there were naught but spoiled brats left in the world!
杜卡特：这不怪你，小马库斯——没想到短短十二年的时间，外面就只剩下这些缺乏耐心的臭小子们了！

James: Aye, but you cannae blame them, can you? How could rocks and lighthouses compete with the tale of three seasoned seafaring spirits?
杜卡特：当然，我也能理解他们，灯塔和礁石的吸引力显然比不过一位阅历丰富的老前辈～

He nods as if he's reluctantly admitting to some truth.
他故作无奈地点了点头。

Thomas: Hmph, some loyalty they've shown ... Up till now, they could nae stop puffing up your work!
马歇尔：哼……明明在前几节发表的时候，他们都对小马库斯的文章赞不绝口呢！

Thomas: "A brand-new approach to documentary literature. A one-of-a-kind writing style. A highly imm-" err, what was it now "A highly immersive reading experience ..."
马歇尔：“纪实文学的全新尝试，独树一帜的写作风格，身临其境的阅读体验……”

The younger ghost recites the remarks indignantly.
年轻的幽灵显然记起了更多的事，他愤愤不平地念叨着。

Thomas: They said it themselves, and then in just a blink, our wee Marcus is no longer a- a- what was it they said "a progressive icon of literary trends" or some old song like that?!
马歇尔：这可都是他们自己说的，怎么才过去这么一会，我们的马库斯就不再是那个代表着新思潮的进步榜样啦?!

Marcus: M-Mr. Thomas, please say no more ...
马库斯：马……马歇尔先生，请不要再说下去了……

Marcus: I could never live up to that kind of praise. Besides, there's no denying it—this is a rejection letter.
马库斯：这些话都过于夸张了，和我的真实能力远远不符。更何况，我如今还收到了这样一封退稿信……

Marcus's cheeks flush in shame, her head lowering deep into her chest.
马库斯双颊通红，她的脑袋埋得更低了。

Suddenly, a flood of thoughts flows into her mind.
突然，她像是想起了什么，纷繁的信息一并涌入了脑海。

Marcus: Oh dear, the way I boasted to that Foundation gentleman about my work ...
马库斯：天啊——我刚刚还大言不惭地向那位基金会的先生夸耀自己的作品……

Marcus: Perhaps he was aware of this letter; maybe he even secretly laughed at my ignorance ...
马库斯：说不定他早就瞥到了这封邮件，甚至已经在心里取笑过我的无知了……

Marcus: Could he have passed by the mailbox on the way here ...?
马库斯：到岛上来的路会经过邮箱吗……?!

Marcus: She repeatedly examines the envelope, as if seeking confirmation of something.
马库斯：她反复地翻看着信件的封面，似乎想确认些什么。

Donald: Oh, ah ... Dinnae worry, Ms. Marcus. The glue on the envelope was intact when we got it; could nae been opened by anyone else.
唐纳德：别、别担心，马库斯，这封信件的胶水完好，没有被其他人拆开过。

Marcus: No, I'm not worried about anything ...
马库斯：不、我没有担心什么……

Still deflating like a punctured balloon, she murmurs to herself.
她像是被戳破的气球般瘪了下去，又忍不住喃喃自语。

Marcus: The Foundation investigates any arcanists pending registration ... They probably examined every letter set to arrive here recently.
马库斯：基金会的工作就是调查未经登记的普通神秘学家……他们很可能早就审查过所有到达这儿的信件了。

Marcus: If so, they might read out this rejection letter at some book club gathering ... then I would become the laughingstock of the entire Eilean Siar—no, the entire United Kingdom!
马库斯：如果他们了解了信上的内容，说不定会在什么读书会或者派对上大肆宣扬一番……我会成为整个埃利安锡尔、不，整个英格兰的笑柄！

Marcus: Oh, oh right, I'll have to write them. Maybe I should ask the Foundation not to report what I boasted about my literary work ... But, should I really join the Foundation?
马库斯：没错，我应该在给基金会的回信中说明这一点，请求他们不要将我在岛上的发言呈报上去……可是，我应该加入基金会吗?

Marcus: The progress of History of the Flannan Isles hasn't been quite as smooth as I'd imagined. Perhaps I do need more time to think about this ...
马库斯：《弗兰南群岛史》的推进并没有我想象中的顺利，也许我需要更多的时间去考虑这件事……

Marcus: Oh, but that investigator did imply that the Foundation is not particularly patient. Would he take my indecision as disrespectful?
马库斯：那位先生也说过，“基金会从不等人”，他会将我的推脱视为一种对基金会的挑衅吗?

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Lightheaded and drained, she braces herself with a fainting step.
她只觉一阵头晕目眩，几乎摇摇欲坠。

The spectral sailors gather around, lifting the fallen letter from the ground together.
立在一旁的、虚无缥缈的水手们簇拥在一起，一同将飘落在地的信纸举了起来。

James: Raise your head, wee Marcus. I'm sure the lads and I can help!
杜卡特：别灰心，小马库斯。我能帮上你的忙～

James: In my admittedly humble ken of writing and reading, isn't it so that writers place their most interesting content at the very beginning, so that they grab their readers and keep them reading?
杜卡特：从我的经验来看，那些出色的作者往往会把最容易引起遐想的内容放在文章的最前面，吸引着我们读下去。

James: So if what you're baiting them in with are the likes of rocks, seagulls, and lighthouses ... well, they're not so much the kind to seize your attention, eh?
杜卡特：而你“阅读”的大多是那些开不了口的礁石、海鸥、灯塔……它们只是些冷冰冰的家伙。

He gives his chest a few pats.
他拍了拍胸膛。

James: Now, my humble self, on the other hand? I've lived here for decades, not to mention I've been here not living for a decade more! I reckon the memories I've got tucked away could make for some pleasing bait indeed.
杜卡特：而我呢？我可是在这儿生活了数十年——显然，作为当事人，我的回忆才是最真实、最具吸引力的！

The quiet ghost timidly speaks up.
一旁沉默许久的幽灵怯懦地开了开口。

Donald: I- uh, I think maybe James is right ... Maybe, you could write, uh, just a wee bit more about our stories ... If you like, that is ...
唐纳德：我、我同意杜卡特先生的说法……或、或许你应该写一写我们……

Donald: Uh ... I only mean, we've spent a lot of time on the islands ... People don't need to come here in person to see what we saw, to hear what we heard ...
唐纳德：呃……我是说，我们在岛上的经历……人们不需要登上这座岛，也能看到我们所看到的，听到我们所听到的……

Donald: Maybe this could clear up all the fear ... maybe make people curious ...
唐纳德：这说不定能缓解他们心中的害怕……让他们提起兴趣……

His suggestion, though a whisper, speaks volumes. The other two ghastly gentlemen look at him in proud approval.
细若蚊虻的建议令其他两位幽灵先生同样眼前一亮。

James: Exactly! They must be quite curious about my past, and of course, more than happy to let these youngins glean something from old James' yarns!
杜卡特：说得对！他们一定对我的过去相当好奇，当然，我也乐意让这些臭小子们学学经验～

James: See, the mind of a seasoned sailor like myself is filled with heart-stirring stories. Aye, I could go on for days ...
杜卡特：你们应该都明白，经验老道的老水手的脑子里可藏着不少让人心潮澎湃的好故事，说几天几夜也说不完……

He proudly strokes his mustache, preserved in spirit, exactly as trim and refined as the old sailor himself.
他骄傲地捋了捋数十年如一日的胡须。

Thomas: You're pulling my leg, mate! Fat chance, they'd give a barnacle's bottom about those ancient salty fish tales of yours!
马歇尔：噢，你一定在开玩笑，老杜卡特！我保证，他们关心的绝对不是你和那些老掉牙的故事！

Intentional or not, the bickering ghosts dispel the gloom hovering around Ms. Marcus.
吵吵嚷嚷的幽灵们将这儿的颓丧一扫而空。

Marcus: Really ...? Would you be willing to share your pasts and perhaps even reveal the truth about your deaths?!
马库斯：真的吗……？先生们，你们愿意讲述你们的过往，揭露死亡的真相吗?!

Thomas: Of course, Marcus. You're our best ... and our only mate. Besides ourselves.
马歇尔：当然，马库斯。你可是我们唯一的朋友。

Donald: I-I also want ... to show more of this place to people ... before we're completely forgotten by the world ...
唐纳德：我、我也想……让更多人了解这儿……在我们被彻底遗忘之前……

Marcus: Thank you so much, all of you.
马库斯：谢谢你们，先生们——！

She bows sincerely, before producing her pen and papers.
她诚恳地鞠了个躬，迅速地掏出了纸笔。

James: Ach, alright ... now where do we start? Aye, that's it—a story from some years ago. Back then, of course, I was more than the humble ghost of a man you see before you. I was the leader of this outfit, and these two were my half-witted lackeys. Yet, driven by our shared honor, faith, and my keen sense of command, we successfully defended these isles from falling into bedlam.
杜卡特：唔……从什么时候讲起呢？十二年前的故事似乎不错，那时候我还是一位出色的船长，带领着两位不成器的属下，在责任感与信念的驱使下，守护着这座岛屿……

James: We drove away more than a few greedy moneybags who wanted to claim these isles for themselves. Oh, and I recall we once saved a gargoyle that was dying of thirst ...
杜卡特：在这期间，我们驱赶了试图将这座岛屿据为己有的贪婪富翁，救助了拒饮海水而几乎渴死的滴水嘴兽……

James: Throughout these heroic endeavors, it was wise old Captain James who stood sentinel over these isles. Until ... the incident ...
杜卡特：在这些故事之中，老杜卡特始终凭借着他的经验与智慧，发挥着无可置疑的重要作用。只可惜，一场意外彻底地改变了他……

The elder ghost rambles on, peering over at his "lackeys" from time to time.
年长的幽灵喋喋不休地回忆着，无不得意地瞥了瞥一旁的两人。

Thomas: Oi, what a load of bilge! If you write down anything this salty old bletherer tells you, you'll nae have a reader left.
马歇尔：嘿，这完全不对——！这些乱七八糟的东西完全与我们的死亡无关，它们根本无法吸引读者的兴趣！

Donald: Oh, it's not that we don't like ... your stories ... Captain ... It's only you went on a bit ... Maybe ... If you don't mind, we can see if the ... uh, lass, likes my story more?
唐纳德：杜卡特先生……你说得太、太啰嗦了……我的故事、更有趣……

James: Oh, aye, belittle your captain's storytelling?! Insubordination, I say! Ingrate whippersnappers ... Dinnae listen to them, wee lassie. With my daring navigational narrative, they'll be begging for your next edition!
杜卡特：臭小子们，你们完全忽略了一位前辈对于航道、对于故事的掌舵能力！只要听我的安排，小马库斯就能写出一篇完美的故事！

Donald: It's only ... Captain ... This story, i-it's not just about you ...
唐纳德：可大家关心的不、不只是你……一个……

All fired up, the trio crowds around Ms. Marcus, jostling for the increasingly scarce space on her manuscript paper.
积极的幽灵们忙不迭地凑近了马库斯，积极地在稿纸上争抢着愈发稀缺的篇幅。

Marcus: Gentlemen! Gentlemen, please quiet yourselves! We'll do it by turns ...
马库斯：先生们，你们可以一个一个来……

Thomas: Aye, fair enough. Then suppose I should have my go. I hope you're ready, lass, because I can guarantee I've got the best of the best. Now, it was my first winter on this island.
马歇尔：接下来你将听到最有趣的故事，马库斯，这要从我在岛上的第一年冬天说起——！

Thomas: On that fateful day, lass, there had been quite a few folk that had alighted with me. Police officers ... Some repairmen from the Northern Lighthouse Board ... I think one of them scarpered off with my oilskin coat after they finished tinkering with the clock in the lighthouse.
马歇尔：那一天，不少人都来到了这里，警官先生、北方灯塔委员会的维修人员，他们搜刮走了我的油皮防水外套，捣鼓着那座停摆的时钟……

Thomas: So there I was, aye, there watching them from afar, waving at them as you do. Not that a soul noticed me. Well, then, and if you are sitting, I advise you to, see then, something out of the ordinary happened ...
马歇尔：我远远地看着他们，向他们挥手，但没有一个人注意到我。很快，意外发生了——

Thomas: For there was a sky-shrouding fog what enveloped all the isles around Eilean Mor. And even our most advanced telescopes couldn't see but half a nautical mile away.
马歇尔：遮天蔽日的浓雾弥漫了弗兰南周边的所有群岛，再好的望远镜也无法看清哪怕半海里以外的东西。

Thomas: Some folk panicked. Ere long, the damp mist soaked straight into everyone's clothes, and that's when I noticed my body had gone and turned transparent ...
马歇尔：人们陷入了慌乱，紧接着，潮湿的水汽把所有人的帽子、皮带都浇透了，我的身体也逐渐变得透明……

Thomas: Then there was a great honking rumble what grew closer and closer. I raised my head—before me was a gigantic, towering wave the likes of which could submerge half the island and a little more besides ...
马歇尔：突然间，巨大的震声越来越近，当我抬头望去，那是一场席卷了几乎半座岛屿的巨浪……

Thomas: D**n near swept away the lot of us. A few survivors threw themselves onto the boats by the shore. So I go to wipe the water from my face, took all but a second, and then, I swear on me mum, when I looked up, the fog had gone, and the survivors' boats were all anchored steadily, must have been five miles out.
马歇尔：它卷起了所有人，活着的人，把他们扔上那些小小的船只。当我擦去眼眶上的水雾后，我惊奇地发现，浓雾消散了，船只们安稳地停泊在了五海里以外的地方。

Thomas: Then it seemed just as quickly as I blinked, they were moving again, racing toward the horizon at a speed of fourteen knots or more!
马歇尔：他们在我的眼中迅速地离去了，时速甚至超过了 14 海里——！

Marcus: Oh my, that is truly astounding ...
马库斯：天啊，马歇尔先生，您的经历真是令人难以相信……

Thomas: Astounding, eh. Maybe, but it's the truth. I'm sure of it. I've kept it locked up tight in my mind, since that day.
马歇尔：事实就是这样，它一直在我的脑子里打转，直到现在。

Donald: We-well, ah, Ms. Marcus, I don't mean to interrupt, only, I don't think that really happened ...
唐纳德：他、他说得一点儿也不全面……马库斯。

Thomas: Oi, Donald! You wait your turn to tell the little lass your story. No need to go mucking mine up. Mark my words, Ms. Marcus, you're going to reel in the readers with this story!
马歇尔：停止你的污蔑，唐纳德！我保证，任何一个读者都会为此动容！

Thomas: Provided, of course, that you choose it as the feature of your next edition.
马歇尔：前提是，马库斯将我的经历作为主要的写作素材，这一定能让大家看得津津有味。

Marcus: I ...
马库斯：我……

Her motionless pen gives away her hesitation.
握住的笔迟迟没有放下。

Donald: Perhaps ... you might like to listen to my story first, Miss Marcus.
唐纳德：或许你应该先听听我的……故事，马库斯。

Donald: When I was a wee bairn, my grandad told me a lot of stories about these islands ... Only back then, they weren't called the Flannan Isles.
唐纳德：在我很小的时候，我的祖父就给我讲述过这儿的故事，那时候……这儿还不叫弗兰南群岛。

Donald: Eilean Mor and its six nearby islands were all together referred to as the Seven Holy Isles.
唐纳德：人们把弗兰南与周边的六座岛屿，一同称为“七圣岛”。

Donald: Someone—well, someone—claimed to have unearthed some skeletons here. And the bones were those of infants, but some said they must have belonged to another race ...
唐纳德：后来，有人声称在这里挖出了不少和人类婴儿相似的骨骼，但大家都说，这些类人骨骼属于另一个种族……

Donald: So, for a while, this place was also known as the Pygmies' Isle.
唐纳德：所以这儿也被称为“矮人岛”。

The emotion carried in his tone is so intense that his ethereal form almost feels corporeal for a second.
唐纳德的语气中流露着深切的向往，虚幻的灵体几乎显出了实质。

Donald: It was because of these stories that I joined the Northern Lighthouse Board and became an assistant lighthouse keeper here right after I finished my schooling.
唐纳德：正是出于这样的原因，中学毕业后，我便加入了北方灯塔委员会，最后在这儿成为了一名候补看守员。

Donald: I hoped to uncover the truth about the Pygmies' Isle ...
唐纳德：我希望能找出“矮人岛”的真相……

Thomas: So ... did you succeed?
马歇尔：那——你找到了吗?

Donald: N-No ... but I managed to find some clues, some signs that there were mysterious animals hereabouts. P-Perhaps, the pygmies really did live here ...
唐纳德：没、没有……但我找到了许多线索，它们证明了一件事，这儿确实有许多神秘动物存在过的痕迹，说、说不定……矮人们真的在这儿定居过……

The other two breathe a sigh of relief.
余下的两人明显松了口气。

James: I'm afraid, there isn't much meat on the bone of that tale, lad; it won't be due for the main dish of the wee lassie's edition.
杜卡特：所以，这些都只是你的推测，它们可当不了专栏的主角。

He strokes his mustache, feigning a sense of pity.
老杜卡特托着胡须，故作无奈地摇了摇头。

Thomas: Sorry, lad, but your story is even mustier than the Captain's, and his was rustier than a knight's armor!
马歇尔：说得没错，老杜卡特。这个故事的年纪听起来比你还要古老，这是一个多么老掉牙的故事啊?!

Thomas: Aye, it might impress a few old folks, but other than that, it's a dud!
马歇尔：我肯定，只有奶奶辈的人才会喜欢它们——!

Donald: Oh! But, but, I-I have evidence, Ms. Marcus. I'll prove it to you ...
唐纳德：我、我还有一些证据，马库斯小姐，我可以向你证明……

The three spooky would-be storytellers devolve into another fruitless argument.
幽灵们吵作一团，斑斓的灵光上下翻飞。

James: Not one of youse has the learning to understand the minds of our lass's readers! She needs a proper story, from a refined gentleman with a wealth of experience.
杜卡特：你们根本不懂大家到底好奇什么，而我是这儿经验最丰富的人！

Thomas: Oh, sod off with your "experience." What the lass needs are the events what lead us to our deaths, not moldy old sailor's yarns!
马歇尔：重点不是你的那些毫无意义的经历，而是我们生前的经历——在这一点上，我的回忆才是最有价值的！

James: Oh aye, memory was it? And you said I was spinning yarns! I've nary seen anything like what you described in all my years here ...
杜卡特：回忆？——我很怀疑其中的真实性，十二年来，我可从来没见过什么遮天蔽日的浓雾……

Donald: Ay-aye ... We cannae go making things up just for a nice story ... oh, but, well Captain ... I don't suppose you even remember what that so-called gargoyle looked like ... do you? Unless you do, I mean ...
唐纳德：编、编造是不对的……杜卡特先生，您、您也一样。您还记得滴水嘴兽的模样吗……？

James: I ...
杜卡特：我……

Their debate is headed nowhere fast.
争执似乎永无止境。

Donald: I think ... we ought to leave it up to Ms. Marcus to decide.
唐纳德：我想……这应该交、交给马库斯来决定。

Thomas: ...
马歇尔：……

James: ...
杜卡特：……

The three shift their gazes onto the girl before them.
幽灵们恍然大悟，目光齐刷刷地汇聚在面前的女孩身上。

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: Captain James's recollection is certainly the longest and most complete. I'm sure the readers will appreciate his thoroughness ...
马库斯：杜卡特先生的回忆篇幅最长，内容也相当完整，读者能从中了解最多的信息……

Marcus: But Thomas's experiences have the closest ties to the outside world and the mysteries of their deaths, which might corroborate some circulating rumors ...
马库斯：而马歇尔先生的经历与外界的联系最为紧密，这或许能和外界的某些传闻互相印证……

Marcus: As for the story of the Pygmies Isle ... It seems like it might have the most rich historical elements ...
马库斯：至于“矮人岛”的故事，它充分地具备了“历史记载”的所有要素……

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: All of these are worthy of being recorded in more detail.
马库斯：这些都是值得一书的内容。

Her evasive gaze can't escape from the three spectral lighthouse keepers' eager eyes.
她的目光试图逃离这里，却不慎对上了三人满溢着热忱的目光。

She finds herself caught between the ghosts and the deep blue sea.
这显然是一个无比艰难的抉择。

Marcus: I ...
马库斯：我……

Ghosts: Ms. Marcus ...
幽灵众：马库斯小姐——

Her lips tremble slightly along with the manuscript paper in her hand.
她的嘴唇翕动，手上的稿纸微颤，终于从齿缝间蹦出几个字来。

Marcus: I-I will include all of your stories. I promise!
马库斯：我……会把它们都用上的，我保证——！

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: "I dare not overstate the literary value of this edition. I can only share with you that it is inspired by the experiences of three ghosts, the very lighthouse keepers who disappeared here twelve years hence."
马库斯：“我无法断言这篇报道的文学价值。我唯一能够笃定的是，其中的素材都来源于幽灵先生们十二年前的亲身经历。”

Marcus: "Dear Ms. Dennehy, I write to you in hopes that this latest edition will prove more than satisfactory."
马库斯：“丹尼希女士，希望您能喜欢这一篇报道。”

Did I make the right choice?
这会是个好选择吗?

Or rather, did I ever have a choice?
或者说，它真的能称得上是一个选择吗?

In any case, I've finally completed my edition.
无论如何，我总算完成了。

Marcus: Phew ... I hope, nothing interrupts the delivery ... Moreover, I hope it doesn't get rejected again ...
马库斯：呼……希望邮差先生一切顺利……但愿之后别再有新的退稿信了……

Illuminated by the dim reflection of the lighthouse's beacon against the pressing clouds, a heavy stack of manuscript papers is tossed into a lonely rusted mailbox.
循着灯塔的微光，一封沉甸甸的稿件被掷入了锈迹斑斑的铁皮匣子里。

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

关于诈骗犯
A Fraudster CH17703-04

A Fraudster
关于诈骗犯

A blank page is folded and unfolded, again and again.
空白的稿纸折了又拆，拆了又折。

Her hands repeat this action unconsciously as Ms. Marcus murmurs anxiously to herself.
伏在书桌上的手无意识地重复着同样的动作，口中喃喃自语。

Marcus: My latest edition of History of the Flannan Isles should have been published in the Daydream Post yesterday ...
马库斯：昨天应该是《弗兰南群岛史》新的一节登报的日子……

Marcus: I know that if the editors weren't satisfied with the entry, it would have been rejected two days prior. But, Mr. Thomas says we've received no letters at all as of yesterday.
马库斯：如果邮报的编辑们不满意我寄出的内容，那它们应该在两天前就被寄回了。而直到昨天，马歇尔先生都没有收到任何一封邮件。

Marcus: So it passed the editors' review ... It must have ...
马库斯：这说明它顺利通过了编辑们的考核……

Marcus: So I should let myself feel some relief ... Thanks to the help of my ghostly friends, this latest edition covered some truly extraordinary topics and gave the readers an opportunity to better understand the Flannan Isles.
马库斯：谢天谢地……多亏了岛上的三位先生，他们为这篇专栏提供了许多帮助，甚至提供了千奇百怪的题材，这一定能让读者们对弗兰南群岛有更确切的了解。

Marcus: Maybe it will even spur a tourism boom for the Flannan Isles. The local council will be very happy for it, I'm sure ...!
马库斯：说不定这还能推动一阵弗兰南群岛的旅游风潮，当局一定会支持这个……！

Marcus: And Ms. Dennehy, well, she'll be Editor of the Year, and get a substantial bonus for her tour of Europe ...
马库斯：而丹尼希女士也能凭借这个顺利通过编辑部的考核，得到优秀编辑的奖金，攒够一笔环游欧洲的资金……

Marcus: She provided me with so much help in writing History of the Isles and in life more generally. She most certainly deserves this ...
马库斯：她在《群岛史》的写作上为我提供了许多帮助，就连生活中也是如此，这些都是她应得的……

Marcus: I hope she will find time to send me a few new books during her trip ...
马库斯：真希望她能在出游时为我捎上几本书……

Marcus: I've never had the chance to read the completed anthology of Story for Sara ... Mr. Allais is truly ingenious. Even just the few excerpts I have from his work have inspired me so much ...
马库斯：《萨拉的故事》我始终没能读到全本……阿尔冯斯先生真是位出色的作家，仅仅是他人辑录的只言片语，就已经足够引人遐想了……

She muses to herself, losing herself in the tranquil depths of her world of literature.
马库斯旁若无人地感慨着，沉浸在文字与书籍的世界里。

Unfortunately, her moment of tranquility passes all too quickly.
遗憾的是，此地的和平与安宁并未持续太久。

Thomas: Ms. Marcus, a whole platoon of postmen just got off the ferry!
马歇尔：马……马库斯，邮差们到岛上来了——！

Somehow unperturbed by the panting ghost popping his head out through the wall, Marcus reaches the meaning behind his message in a sudden rising start.
气喘吁吁的幽灵从墙外探出头来，马库斯准确地阅读出了更“重要”的信息。

Marcus: A "platoon" of postmen?
马库斯：邮差先生……们?

Thomas: Aye, a whole slew of them. The lads and I think it must mean your new edition was a cracking success!
马歇尔：没错，他们来了好几个人，很显然，这意味着你的故事大获成功——！

Thomas: All those high-nosed hobnobs are probably planning to invite you to give lectures all around the world—now dinnae go forgetting us with your sudden fame. Remember it was your ghostly mates who got you here!
马歇尔：他们也许正打算邀请你去世界各地发表演讲呢～你可别忘了在发表感言时提到我们的名字，来自岛上的马歇尔先生和他的幽灵朋友们。

Marcus: ...!
马库斯：……！

Ms. Marcus rushes to her coat, and together they speed toward the island's mail drop-off.
一前一后的身影快步越过了门槛，奔向了岛上唯一的对外通信点。

Three ghastly gentlemen and one gasping girl stand in front of the small mailbox, exchanging anxious looks.
三位幽灵先生和呼吸急促的姑娘在不大的邮筒前站定，面面相觑。

Donald: Ahoy gentlemen ... Ms- Ms. Marcus ... The postmen already came and went. Left as soon as they'd dropped off these letters ...
唐纳德：先生们……马库斯……邮差先生们已经离开了……把这些信件留在这儿之后，便急匆匆地离开了……

Thomas: That's it ...? They dinnae ask for any local postcards, perhaps an autograph from the stars of the latest edition ...?
马歇尔：他们只留下了这些信……？就没问我们要点明信片、私人签名之类的……

Donald: Well, ah, no. No. I suppose I dinnae want to spook them. Since Ms. Marcus asked us not to ...
唐纳德：你、你忘了吗？马歇尔先生……他们、看不见我们……

James: Oh, aye, they were the ones spooked, eh? Just as well, lad. We'll need some time to adjust to our new lives as undead celebrities. Now stiffen up, only a landsman gets nervous over a little rising tide.
杜卡特：没什么可怀疑的，朋友们……孩子们偶尔会紧张，而对于即将成为岛上明星的我们来说，豁达一点儿总没什么坏处。

Marcus: These letters ... are all for me?
马库斯：这些信……都是寄给我的?

The ghosts nod in unison.
幽灵们不约而同地点了点头。

James: It can only be, wee miss. You've most certainly written a fine piece. Only natural that it might bring about a bit of zealotry.
杜卡特：这完全能够理解，小马库斯——你写出了这么好的作品，读者们热情一些也在所难免。

Marcus: Still, there are so many letters ...
马库斯：可是，它们实在是太多了……

After adjusting her scarf, in an attempt to cover the flush of her cheeks, she reaches over-quickly for one of the letters.
马库斯紧了紧围巾，压住了泛上脸颊的期待，小心翼翼地拆开了其中的一封。

But as she opens it, the words within leave her painfully stunned.
清晰而直白的文字落入她的眼中，令她僵在原地。

Marcus: "I want to apologize for my candor, writing to you as a fan of the much-celebrated writer for History of the Flannan Isles."
马库斯：“很冒昧向您寄出这样一封信，《弗兰南群岛史》的作者。”

Marcus: "But I feel I must express my disappointment. Not just for myself, but for the thousands of other readers now feeling equally deceived."
马库斯：“但我想，我必须要向您表达我的心声。这不仅仅是为了我，同样是为了千百个同样蒙难的读者。”

Marcus: "When I first read your column, I was captivated by its vivid psychological descriptions and the detailed introductions, prompting me to buy issue after issue of the magazine and even recommend it to my friends and family ..."
马库斯：“当我初读文章时，我确实被其中生动的心理描写、作者热切的介绍所吸引，它们推动着我购置了一期又一期的报纸，并将它们推荐给了我的诸多亲朋好友……”

Marcus: "Yet, I see now you and your publisher have concocted a massive fraud, leading us in on a long con to rob us any satisfaction!"
马库斯：“可是，您却联合出版社一同编造了一个巨大的谎言！——！”

Her hand freezes in place, unable or unwilling to turn the page.
翻页的手僵在了原地。

Marcus: "The Daydream Post never stopped praising the upcoming edition of History of the Flannan Isles!"
马库斯：“《白日梦邮报》无时无刻不在向我们夸赞着未来一期的《弗兰南群岛史》！”

Marcus: "They claimed it would finally lift the cloud of mystery looming over the Flannan Isles once and for all!"
马库斯：“你们声称，这将会是有史以来关于弗兰南群岛的最详细记载！将会拨开蒙在弗兰南群岛上空最大的乌云——！”

Marcus: "I waited eagerly for almost a week for this vaunted new edition that was supposed to unveil all mysteries ..."
马库斯：“我怀着热切的期待苦等了近乎一周，等待着这篇能让一切谜团都尘埃落定的新专栏……”

Marcus: "Only for you to introduce some sad old captain with a ghost story, an overly foggy day, followed by some island-swallowing wave, and then a bit of old history about these Seven Holy Isles ..."
马库斯：“您介绍了幽灵岛上的老船长，介绍了那场遮天蔽日的迷雾和滔天的巨浪，甚至还普及了古老的七圣岛传闻……”

Marcus: "And nothing else."
马库斯：“可之后呢——?!”

Marcus: "You claim these 'ghosts' have spent more than twelve years on this island. Yet you still do not provide a shred of explanation concerning their disappearance? Or why is it they became ghosts? You take the word of these ghosts at face value, but are their memories even reliable? Do they have any credible evidence?"
马库斯：“这三位声称自己在岛上呆了十二年之久的先生到底是如何失踪的？他们又为何成为了幽灵？幽灵的记忆可靠吗？他们有什么可信的证据吗?”

Marcus: "If these are truly ghosts, then why can't they tell us where their missing bodies are? How can you possibly prove this isn't just another arcanist rambling about her own fairy tales?"
马库斯：“如果他们真是幽灵，那他们的尸体又去了哪儿？不然的话，您又何以证明这不是神秘学家们又一次的胡言乱语呢?”

Marcus: "You try to obfuscate the hard questions with these twisted yarns, but all you've done is create more mysteries, stretching them out like old taffy! But I see through it: you never had any intention to conclude this story! You've been stringing us along the whole time!"
马库斯：“您试图用这些互相扭打、结成死结的证词糊弄我们，可它们反而制造了更多、更多的谜团，它们不断延伸，延伸，仿佛永远没有尽头——！”

Marcus: "You, madame, are nothing but a fraudster!"
马库斯：“您是个骗子——！”

Marcus: Marcus stands still, her mouth agape, unable to make a sound.
马库斯：马库斯怔怔地站着，她张了张口，却什么声音也发不出来。

Donald: This letter is ... tr-truly terrible. M-maybe it's just a joke, like the awful pranks Captain James and Thomas sometimes play on me.
唐纳德：这封信……可真吓人……比马歇尔和杜卡特先生的恶、恶作剧还可怕……

James: Now, now, steady on, wee Ms. Marcus ... It's but a wide shot across the bow. Don't mistake it for a barrage! The rest of these are sure to be glowing reviews.
杜卡特：咳、别紧张，小马库斯……显然，这只是某些极端读者的偏见，他不能代表所有人的意见，对……吧?

Thomas: Aye, the old foghorn's right. Every twee lass or lad thinks he's a critic these days. Let's leave it to professionals, eh ... where's that letter from Ms. Dennehy?
马歇尔：没错，我们应该阅读一些专业人士的建议……像是《白日梦邮报》的丹尼希女士，她主导了《弗兰南群岛史》的出版……

Thomas: If anyone knows what way the wind's blowing, it'll be her.
马歇尔：我相信，这位编辑女士一定能对你的故事做出公正的评判!

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

In a daze, Marcus rummages through the pile of letters as if seeking a life preserver in a stormy sea.
神情恍惚的马库斯开始紧张地在信件堆里翻找，企图寻获她的救命稻草。

Soon enough, she finds what she is looking for.
很快，她便得偿所愿。

Marcus: "Dear Ms. Marcus, our illustrious writer for the History of the Flannan Isles column."
马库斯：“致《弗兰南群岛史》专栏作者，马库斯小姐”。

Marcus: "Dear Ms Marcus, first as a matter of business, I must admit that yesterday's issue of the Daydream Post, featuring your History of the Isles, was a tremendous sales success."
马库斯：“首先，我们希望向您表达祝贺，昨天，载有《群岛史》的《白日梦邮报》一经发表，便取得了销量上的巨大成功。”

Marcus: "Spurred on by the delay caused by your previous edition, it seems our journal was sold out within hours by your eager readers ..."
马库斯：“或许是由于上一节的修改延期所致，仅仅在数小时内，您翘首以待许久的读者们便将油墨未干的报纸抢购一空……”

Marcus: "But we'd only just started on the second printing before a group of frenzied readers stormed up to our office."
马库斯：“但在我们准备增发更多刊物时，某些富于激情的读者们便涌入了我们的出版社，他们占领了这里。”

Marcus: "They were waving their arms, shouting things like 'Refund!' 'This is fraud!' and one particularly exuberant fellow claimed he'd be 'Writing to the Prime Minister to report you' ..."
马库斯：“这是一件令人始料未及的事，他们挥舞着双臂，高呼着‘退钱！’‘你们这是欺诈！’‘我要向市长先生写信投诉你们’之类并不难懂的话……”

Marcus: "After communicating with them, we realized they were all loyal readers of History of the Flannan Isles."
马库斯：“了解原委后，我们意识到他们的身份相当统一，《弗兰南群岛史》的忠实读者们。”

Marcus: "They called your History of the Isles a premeditated scam disguised as a documentary. They accused us of conspiring with you to deceive everyone ..."
马库斯：“他们居然认为您的《群岛史》是一场蓄谋已久的欺诈，认为我们同您一同欺骗了所有人……”

Marcus: "What absurd allegations! They even redirected their dissatisfaction with History of the Isles onto us, a small-time publishing house."
马库斯：“这是多么荒唐的言论啊——！它们竟然将对《群岛史》本身的不满转嫁在我们这样一家小小的出版社上。”

Marcus: "To be perfectly candid, we did launch a significant promotional campaign before the release of this issue. However, it was not a hasty decision; it was out of our trust in you!"
马库斯：“诚然，我们确实在本期《群岛史》发布前便展开了规模不小的前期宣传工作。但这并非是我们仓促的决定，而是出于对您的信任！”

Marcus: "You promised us in your submission that all your descriptions were based on the first-hand experiences of those directly involved. You are responsible for their authenticity!"
马库斯：“是您——！您在来稿中向我们承诺，您的所有文字都出于当事人的亲身经历，您会对其中的真实性负责！”

Marcus: "Regrettably, things have now developed beyond anyone's imagination."
马库斯：“但很遗憾，事情的发展超乎了所有人的想象。”

Marcus: "We believe that if you cannot sufficiently meet the readers' expectations in the next edition with a sensational conclusion or some sort of revealing of ultimate truth ..."
马库斯：“我们认为，如果您无法在下一期的《弗兰南群岛史》中尽可能地满足读者们的期待，给出一个轰动性的结论，或是揭晓故事的重大真相……”

Marcus: "Otherwise, you may need to consider a new pseudonym, or perhaps a change of subject beyond the Flannan Isles, or more simply, give up on the job altogether."
马库斯：“您或许不得不准备一个新的笔名，更换一个弗兰南群岛以外的新课题，或是……放弃这份工作。”

Marcus: "We sincerely hope you consider our advice above."
马库斯：“我们诚恳地希望您能考虑上述建议。”

flop
“噗——”

The bitter sting of the letter saps the strength from her legs, as she collapses slowly to the ground and into a heap.
马库斯瘫坐在地，再也无力负担这沉甸甸的信纸。

James: ...
杜卡特：……

Thomas: ...
马歇尔：……

Donald: ...
唐纳德：……

The ghosts attempt, as best they can, to make out what the rest of the letters hold.
幽灵们一言不发，默契地扎进了信件堆里。

Thomas: "It is despicable that you would abuse the sacred power of the pen to promote this bizarre so-called arcanum. And how much worse for its plodding, unconnected narrative, if anything at all of what you said was true, it would only mean our world had gone mad!"
马歇尔：“您是个可耻的作家，您滥用自己的纸笔，以所谓的神秘学搪塞一切，如果一切都如您所言，这该是一个多么荒诞的世界啊！”

Thomas: Heh—wrong letter, sorry lass.
马歇尔：不，不是这个——

He feigns a soft bombing whistle as he tosses the letter aside.
他故作轻快地吁了口气，毫不犹豫地将这封信扔到一旁。

James: Allow me, Ms. Marcus—if my years have proved of any use at all, it has been in discerning truth from slander.
杜卡特：来听听我这封，小马库斯——这正是经验所赋予我们的鉴别力。

James: "I wish to extend my congratulations to the author. For what must have been a handsome fee you earned yourself with your talents."
杜卡特：“向您表达祝贺，作者女士。我笃信，您凭借巧妙的、故弄玄虚的能力攫取了丰厚的稿费。”

James: "Chief of which must be in huckstering and forgery. I pray you'll fare well during the coming police interrogations for this fraud of an edition! Hopefully, they'll be trained to make sense of this arcanist tat!"
杜卡特：“但我同样担忧您是否能顺利通过警察署的欺诈质询！但愿他们会理解所谓神秘学家的胡言乱语～”

James: ...
杜卡特：……

James: Apologies, it seems wisdom does not always spring from age ...
杜卡特：咳、经验偶尔也会欺骗我们。当然，这同样是经验的一部分。

Donald: Oh! Oh, um ... I think, maybe, I found one that isn't quite so terrible ...
唐纳德：我找到了一封，它看上去似乎没有那么可怕……

Marcus: ... Really?!
马库斯：……真的吗?!

Donald: "D-dear author, I wanted you to know that I fully understood the deep meaning behind this publication."
唐纳德：“作者女士，我已经彻底理解了您的意图。”

Donald: "It is crystal clear that you drew inspiration from the stories of Penelope and the Danaides as you prepared us for an endless tapestry and a b-bottomless bucket ..."
唐纳德：“毫无疑问，您一定从珀涅罗珀与达那伊得斯姊妹的故事中得出了灵感，为我们编出了一条绵长的织物、一个无底的水桶……”

Donald: "I'm s-so glad to be able to bear witness to what you've created—a torture to the senses which has left me wishing to swap places with Tantalus himself ..."
唐纳德：“很高兴我能通过您所给予的磨难，这甚至令我对坦塔罗斯先生都有所共情……”

Donald: "So long, and good riddance to your interminable stories!"
唐纳德：“感谢您毫……毫无中心思想的故事，再见！！！”

Donald: Ah! S-Sorry, Ms. Marcus. I was never much for reading—was that not ... good?
唐纳德：——！抱、抱歉，马库斯小姐。

Marcus: ... Thank you all the same, Donald.
马库斯：无论如何……感谢您的好意，唐纳德先生。

She nods weakly toward Donald.
马库斯费力地朝着唐纳德颔首致意。

Then, in a slow fall, to match the crashing waves against the shore, she collapses completely to the ground.
而后，她彻底地瘫倒下去。

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

主角们
The Protagonists CH17703-05

The Protagonists
主角们

Inside the Room
房间内

The ghosts clump together anxiously in the dim room.
屋内的灯光昏黄，幽灵们的影子挤作一团。

Marcus sits up in bed after a struggle, the harrowing words in those letters still writhing through her.
马库斯挣扎着从床上坐起，信纸上历历在目的笔迹仍在刺痛着她。

All coming together in a catastrophic clash of anxiety, dread, and helplessness.
但这显然不会是混乱的终点。

The nearby voices grow louder, dragging her out from one kind of havoc ...
耳边窸窸窣窣的声响愈演愈烈，将她从混乱的意识中唤醒，又落入另一场——

To the next.
更大的混乱。

James: I'm dreadfully sorry, lass.
杜卡特：事情发生在这座岛上，我很遗憾。

James: But let's get on to righting the ship: we cannae bilge the water if we dinnae find the holes. It's evident to me that our failure must be laid on Mr. Thomas—it's very clear it was his far-fetched tale that set your readers off!
杜卡特：但我必须声明：这一场失败的主要原因，都需要归咎于马歇尔的部分——是他的部分拖累了整篇专栏！

James: I cannae imagine anyone wasting their precious time reading something so bizarre and fanciful, the likes of which surely spoiled many an afternoon tea!
杜卡特：想想看，朋友们——！究竟有谁会想在美好的清晨或下午茶时间，在疲惫工作的间隙，阅读到这样一篇充满着谜团与不可知物的可怕文章呢！

He crosses his arms, turning with a vexed expression to his compatriot.
他双手抱胸，对年轻人做出的仓促决定相当痛心。

Thomas: Oh, it was my part, aye? Here and I thought, the captain goes down with the ship.
马歇尔：我完全不认同你的指责，老杜卡特，你只是在逃避责任……是你的部分毁掉了一切！

Thomas: Didn't you hear what the wee miss had to say? Her readers want positivity and progress, not ancient prattle! It was your bit what steered us onto the rocks!
马歇尔：正如马库斯所说的，现在的时代，是一个进步的时代，是一个积极向上的时代。而你的故事恰恰相反，它完全背离了这个时代，有如一架脱轨的火车！

Thomas: Those yarns of yours were so long they'd nary fit in my granny's attic. Ms. Marcus' readers probably nodded off half-way through!
马歇尔：老套的内容和任谁都能猜出来的情节发展，它们比我奶奶阁楼上积的灰还要多上几层——更谈不上半点真实！

James: Oh, aye, whine all you like. What do you know of story-telling, eh? I'll bet you dinnae even know your Shakespeare from your Shelley!
杜卡特：哼～不懂经典的家伙，快找根绳子把自己系系好吧——不然，我怀疑你那轻浮的审美也要飘到天上去了……

James's translucent face turns red with anger, his mustache bristling.
杜卡特先生的面色通红，他的胡须高高地翘起。

Donald: S-Stop please ... both of you ...
唐纳德：你……你们不要再吵了……

Marcus: Sigh ... Please calm down, gentlemen. Let's hear what Donald has to say.
马库斯：呼……请冷静下来，马歇尔先生，杜卡特先生。我想你们应该听一听唐纳德先生的建议。

James: ...
杜卡特：……

Thomas: ...
马歇尔：……

Donald: Well ... I don't mean to speak ... out of turn, b-but lying is a worse sin, so speak I must. I reckon it was both of your stories that did this ...
唐纳德：或许我不该说出真相……但、但谎言是更加可怕的魔鬼，所以我必须得说……你们两个讲述的回忆都存在严重的问题……

Donald: Captain, your story was nothing more than a chance for you to show off. You distorted the truth, even when it went against what Thomas described ...
唐纳德：杜卡特先生太、太过执着于表现自己了，为了这个目的，你夸大了其中的情节，曲解了其中的真实部分，甚至与马歇尔先生的内容相互矛盾……

Donald: I think, that our story, Ms. Marcus's work ... I mean, it should have focused on the mysteries of the Flannan Isles themselves.
唐纳德：可马库斯小姐的故事应该讲述的是……弗兰南群岛的谜团。

Thomas: Well said, Donald!
马歇尔：相当有力的论证，唐纳德！

Donald: A-And you ...
唐纳德：你、你也是……

Donald: Thomas ... your story had just as many mistakes! Just of a different sort, you did exactly what Ms. Marcus' readers say they hated! You gave her story with mysteries, aye, but no ending! How could anyone be happy with that?
唐纳德：你的故事犯了另一个错误，马歇尔先生。你完全忽略了编辑的建议，你只顾自己的体验，完全不在乎读者的接受程度，甚、甚至没有给大家解开任何一个谜团……！

Thomas: I just said what I knew, nothing more—no lies, no reservations!
马歇尔：我可把知道的一切都说了！——没有半句虚话！

James: Twelve years and more we've been on this island, still you both know nothing about this place, about anything ... And you dinnae have at least the wits to trust someone with experience.
杜卡特：你在这儿呆了十二年，可你还是什么都不知道……你这该死的家伙，我以高出你十五年的阅历断言，你只是想让其他人陷入与你一样的深渊！

Thomas: ...
马歇尔：……

Donald: A-Actually, Ms. Marcus, I'm afraid, well, maybe this isn't our fault entirely either ...
唐纳德：马库斯小姐，您、您也负有不可推卸的责任……

Marcus: ... You're blaming me?
马库斯：我……？

Donald: Well-bl-blame, no. Only, you were the one who wrote down our stories. We're not writers, miss. We dinnae know what bits are important, or how to finish the story ... Maybe your readers are angry for good reason ...
唐纳德：您没能发现他们存在的纰漏，没能及时地将他们的内容从……从您的作品中剔除出去，才因此造成了读者们的不满、出版社的混乱……

Donald: M-maybe you should have based the edition on what I said about the Seven Holy Isles and the Pygmies ... Then you could have given them a proper investigation, something to really talk about.
唐纳德：您应该以我的回忆为原型，讲述七圣岛的历史和矮人们的传说……这说不定能引发读者们的热烈讨论，甚、甚至还能从中收获源源不断的创作灵感……

Thomas: Ach! So now we see Donald. If only we had listened to you, eh? Not so noble now, eh? Face it, lad, that story of yours was weaker than watered-down whisky!
马歇尔：嚯……原来你只是在吹嘘自己的部分！要我看，里面到处都是乱糟糟的漏洞和不切实际的幻想，根本不能称为完整的记录！

James: Thomas is right, laddie. Though, only in as much as they say about broken clocks. The truth of the matter is clear, lads. The wee miss should have only used my story.
杜卡特：仅在这一点上，我十分认同马歇尔的说法。结论显而易见，我的回忆才是最完整的！

Donald: Oh, aye, and what makes you say that ...?
唐纳德：那请问，你又有什么高、高见呢?

Ghosts: &.....*%#@!$(.....
幽灵众：&……*%#@！￥（……

Marcus: Please stop ...
马库斯：不……

The spirited voices of their heated quarrel engulf the entire room.
在近乎绝望的目光中，更尖锐的、互不示弱的争执声彻底堵塞了这里。

In her despair, Marcus begins to question herself.
马库斯眼前一片灰暗。

When exactly did this story of mine turn into a "catastrophe"?
故事，究竟是何以成为事故的呢?

Was it when the deluge of angry letters arrived?
是在那些蜂拥而至的信件们堆积成山的时候?

Was it when I submitted the revised manuscript?
是在我投出新一篇稿件的时候?

Or was it when I hesitated to choose between their stories?
还是在我面对幽灵先生们丰富的故事素材，却迟迟无法选择的时候?

Marcus: Maybe I'm not truly cut out for this job ...?
马库斯: 我真的适合这份工作吗……?

Marcus: When I began writing, I wanted to record everything ... Every piece of knowledge, especially those lesser-known facts, things that might be lost in time, that might go silent, if I- I wasn't there ...
马库斯: 当我开始写作时，我希望能够将我所阅读的一切都记录下来……那些不被人们理解的知识，或许，它们不仅仅属于一小撮孤独的世界，也并不沉默寡言……

Marcus: Stories that could be exquisite, delicate, captivating, or at least relatable ...
马库斯: 它们同样有着设计精巧的一页、细腻的一页，能够令人驻足，令人向往，也能引起共鸣……

Marcus: But ... what has all that work brought me?
马库斯: 可……我都做了些什么啊……

As Marcus closes her eyes, agonizing memories flash over the theater of her mind mercilessly.
马库斯闭上眼睛，先前的一幕幕无情地掠过她的眼前。

Her dream seems to be pulling further and further away from her.
它们似乎与理想背道而驰。

Marcus: I dreamed that my work would help humankind to understand and accept arcanum ...
马库斯: 我希望人类能逐渐理解、接受神秘学……

Marcus: But now my column is being bashed by my once loyal readers. They even stormed the Daydream Post ... Poor Ms. Dennehy must have lost her chance at the Editor of the Year award ...
马库斯: 可我的专栏遭到了读者们的不满与抨击，他们甚至因此闯入了《白日梦邮报》……可怜的丹尼希编辑，她一定没法通过优秀编辑的评选了……

Marcus: Perhaps ... oh, what if this leads the entire community to distrust any future writing related to arcanum ... Or worse, those who still read them might become labeled as occultists or lunatics ...
马库斯: 或许……或许读者们再也不会相信任何与神秘学有关的故事了，神秘学有关的作品……不、乃至读者都会被套上故弄玄虚、胡言乱语的罪名……

Marcus: Then human society's discrimination against arcanists might grow even more severe ... not just in the Flannan Isles—no, maybe against the entire arcanist world! And I ... will be the catalyst whose horrible writing divided our two races even further ...
马库斯: 甚至人类都会因此对弗兰南群岛，不、对整个神秘学世界都产生更严重的偏见！……而我是致使两个种族隔阂加深的罪人。

Marcus: It's all my fault ...
马库斯: 这全是我的错……

Marcus covers her face with her palms. But no amount of self-pity can drown out the squabbling spirits.
马库斯捂着脸，屋内始终持续的嘈杂毫不避讳地窜入了她的耳中。

Marcus: I only hoped to alleviate their loneliness by "reading" this island and documenting its stories ... I just wanted to share them with the world ...
马库斯：我希望能通过我的阅读，通过记录朋友们的故事令他们摆脱困于岛上的孤独，能被世人所知，能交到更多的朋友……

Marcus: But now these ghostly gentlemen, protagonists in my latest disaster, are tearing into one another before my eyes ... My writing didn't bring them happiness. It intensified their misfortune ...
马库斯：可身为主人公的幽灵先生们因此反目，他们互相攻讦，针锋相对，陷入分裂……我的创作并没有令他们获得半点儿幸福，反而加剧了他们的不幸……

Marcus: *sob*
马库斯：呜呜……

Marcus: B-But all I wanted to do was tell a fascinating story ...
马库斯：可、可我最初只是想讲述一个美好而有趣的故事啊……

She lets out a loud cry from her corner, hoping to silence the continual bickering, even for a moment.
她在仅属于自己的一隅里大声疾呼，希望能短暂地掩去周围的喧闹与嘈杂。

Marcus: ...?
马库斯：……?

To her surprise, the argument stops indeed.
耳边的争执声似乎真的停下了。

Marcus: Did that ... actually work?
马库斯：是我的心理暗示起效了吗?

Thomas: Oi, pick yourself up, Marcus! Someone's at the door.
马歇尔：嘿，快醒醒，马库斯——！有人来找你了。

The girl comes back to her senses, pulling herself to the door by will alone.
她在恍惚中回过神来。

A figure, at once familiar and strange, stands before her.
一抹熟悉而陌生的灰白映入她的眼帘。

Hofmann: Good morning, madam. My name is Hofmann, and I've come a long way to see you.
霍夫曼：我是霍夫曼。很高兴见到你，马库斯小姐。

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

创作自白

Preface CH17703-06

Preface
创作自白

The figure of a woman dressed in a long brown coat walks ahead at a steady pace, followed by the nervous young lady.
灰白的身影不紧不慢地走在前头，胆战心惊的少女小心地跟了上去。

Marcus: E-Excuse me, are you from the Foundation ...?
马库斯：啊……您，您也是从基金会来的……?

Hofmann: Yes. It seems I will be able to skip my introduction.
霍夫曼：看来我不用作过多的介绍了。

Hofmann nods, seemingly ignoring or neglecting the panic in Marcus's tone.
霍夫曼点了点头，并没有细究对方语气中的慌乱。

Marcus: I-I'm so sorry ... for having made you come all this way. I-I will respond to the Foundation as soon as possible. I-I promise!
马库斯：很、很抱歉……特地劳烦您过来这儿，我、我会尽快答复基金会的，请、请您放心——！

Hofmann halts her steps and turns around.
脚步停了下来。

Her puzzled gaze accurately catches Marcus's evasive eyes.
一双略有疑惑的眼转了过来，准确地捕捉住了另一双努力躲闪的眼。

Hofmann: ...?
霍夫曼：……？

Hofmann: The Foundation's application has been approved by the local government. From today onward, a small portion of this archipelago will be set aside for our use as an experimentation site.
霍夫曼：我们的申请通过了当地政府的审批。从即日起，基金会将征用弗兰南群岛的一小块区域，作为我们的备用试验点。

Marcus: Experiments ...?
马库斯：实验点……？

Hofmann: Yes, for an upcoming observation project, jointly operated between the Foundation and Laplace. It involves a new arcanist theory.
霍夫曼：是的。这是一个新的观测项目，由圣洛夫基金会与拉普拉斯科算中心联合运行，涉及到一项新兴神秘学理论。

Marcus: Am I ... not supposed to know about this?
马库斯：我是不是……不应该知道这些？

Marcus takes a few steps back with a flinch.
马库斯紧张地退缩了几步。

Hofmann: No. No, it's not confidential. Laplace does not intend to keep its work here a secret.
霍夫曼：没关系，这并非保密项目。就具体责任制而言，负责追责的也应该是科算中心，但他们显然并无此意。

Marcus: Observation project ... Laplace ... Emerging arcanist theory ...
马库斯：科算中心项目……研究期刊……新的神秘学理论……

Marcus: Oh! I think ... I've read about this before—the study of ley lines?
马库斯：噢——！我似乎阅读过……它的名字是——理线学？

Hofmann: Correct. Laplace published the theory in their second edition of the Frontier of Times journal. Just some basic introductions, of course, nothing monumental.
霍夫曼：是的，科算中心将它刊登在《时代前沿》期刊的第二版，当然，只涉及了一些基础的介绍，影响力不大。

Hofmann: Hofmann nods, nonplussed by Marcus's breadth of reading.
霍夫曼：霍夫曼点点头，似乎对对方的阅读量毫不意外。

Hofmann: The Foundation will be responsible for this project's application procedures and field confirmation. Of course, we will aim to minimize any impacts on the natural surroundings as much as possible.
霍夫曼：在这个观测项目中，基金会负责前期的文书申请与实地确认工作。当然，我们会尽量克制对弗兰南群岛的负面影响。

She turns around to look at the solitary tower perched on the cliff.
她回过头去，望了望那座孤独地驻在山崖的小房子。

Hofmann: Should you, or they, have any concerns, please contact our Eilean Siar branch for further assistance.
霍夫曼：如果你、或是他们对此有任何疑虑，可以向基金会驻埃利安锡尔办事处提出异议。

Marcus: So ... you are not here about my investigation?
马库斯：所以……您并非为了上次的调查而来?

Hofmann: My sole task here is to survey the Flannan Isles. I've no time nor inclination to meddle in the affairs of some unregistered arcanist.
霍夫曼：我当前的工作是考察弗兰南群岛，而非调查在外的神秘学家。

The lingering specter of the other investigator finally fades from her mind.
马库斯松了口气，那位过于轻浮的调查员先生的身影终于从脑海中淡去。

Hofmann: My visit is not part of any assigned mission.
霍夫曼：当然，此次拜访也并不在我的工作流程之内。

Marcus: ... I see.
马库斯：……原来如此。

Hofmann: This is out of my own interest, as a reader.
霍夫曼：这出于我作为普通读者的个人意愿。

Marcus: What?!
马库斯：什么……?!

Marcus: You ... read my column?
马库斯：您……也读了我的专栏?

Hofmann: Yes, from the first edition to the very latest. I must say, they have been very informative.
霍夫曼：连载至今的《弗兰南群岛史》专栏令我印象深刻。

The horrifying letters from before seem to have grown wings, ready to swarm Marcus once more.
那些令人恐惧的信件似乎长出了翅膀，要再一次淹没她的脑海。

She bows her head as if awaiting the imminent drop of a guillotine.
她像是触电般低下头去，等待着一场亲临的审判。

Hofmann: Out of curiosity, I went through the trouble of finding some of your earlier works.
霍夫曼：我读过了你发表在《白日梦邮报》的新专栏。出于好奇，我翻看了你之前的许多作品。

Hofmann: You have covered a wide range of topics in great detail. Unfortunately, it seemed the space provided to you by your magazine has been, till now, quite limited.
霍夫曼：它们涉猎极广，内容详实。遗憾的是，报纸上的版面似乎对你造成了不小的限制。

Marcus: Oh, those ... They weren't much ... Just a few jottings, really ... I thought nobody remembered them ... haha ...
马库斯：它们只是些没什么作用的随笔……哈哈……我还以为大家早就已经遗忘了……

Though her body feels stiff, Marcus forces out an awkward smile.
马库斯的身体僵硬，勉强挤出一个尴尬的笑容。

Hofmann: Arcanum and Lighthouse Lens Maintenance. Do you remember this article?
霍夫曼：《神秘学与灯塔透镜维修指南》，你还记得这篇文章吗?

Marcus: ... That was my first submission after arriving in the Flannan Isles from Romania.
马库斯：……那是离开罗马尼亚、登上弗兰南群岛后，我写下的第一篇故事。

Hofmann: Hofmann nods, indifferent to the nearly overwhelming blush on Marcus's cheeks.
霍夫曼：霍夫曼点了点头，似乎并不在意对方几乎快要漫过耳尖的红，自顾自地说了下去。

Hofmann: The way you relayed the specifics of Lighthouse keeping with such great enthusiasm, it was as if you felt it had something to offer to every reader.
霍夫曼：作者以极高的热情介绍着灯塔相关的知识，希望将自己了解的一切都毫无保留地献给每一位读者。

Hofmann: The internal structure, differences in lighthouse design in various locales, the evolution of light sources, advancements in lamp maintenance ... Even the ideal number of lighthouse keepers.
霍夫曼：内部构造、不同环境下的塔身形制差异、光源的变迁历史与灯具保养法的进步，甚至还谈及了最合适的灯塔管理人数……

Hofmann: Frankly, I found it perhaps a little overwrought but still undoubtedly worth reading.
霍夫曼：坦白说，那是一篇相当繁杂的文章，但也是篇值得一读的文章。

Marcus: I'm sor—hmm?!
马库斯：我很抱歉……嗯?!

Hofmann: "Dear friends, imagine a flame that requires no fuel, immune to extinguishing no matter in cold wind or heavy rain, and shines bright enough to illuminate the sea even through the thickest of fog ..."
霍夫曼：“朋友们，让我们想象一下，倘若真的有这样一团不需要燃料、不会因寒风与露水的扰动而熄灭的火源，它足够明亮，足以在茫茫的海雾中照亮每一艘航船的终点……”

Hofmann: "Might we then be able to save on nearly a century's worth of gas or electricity expenses ... and redirect those funds to more pressing matters?
霍夫曼：“我们是否就能够免去几乎百余年的煤油或是电力支出……从而将这笔资金投入到更紧迫的地方?”

Hofmann: "As it happens, on a small island surrounded by warm waters, there exists just such fiery critters. These docile and nocturnal creatures could well be suitable for use as endlessly reproducible light sources ..."
霍夫曼：“而在某片温暖的洋流所环绕的小岛，那儿正生活着这样滚烫的魔精。它们温驯，昼伏夜出，正适合作为灯塔光源来使用……”

Hofmann: There were many more descriptions like this.
霍夫曼：而类似的描写并不在少数。

Marcus: ... I'm surprised you remember them so well, Madam Hofmann.
马库斯：……您记得很清楚，霍夫曼女士。

Hofmann: Ms. Marcus, you must understand one thing. Though discrimination against arcanists has become less severe in our era, it remains, for most humans, an ingrained habit.
霍夫曼：马库斯小姐，你应该能明白，尽管这个时代的人们并不像以往那样憎恨神秘学家，但对大多数人而言，这仍是他们潜移默化的习惯。

Hofmann: One that won't change overnight.
霍夫曼：它们很难在一朝一夕中改变。

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Hofmann: Why are you still trying to introduce arcanum to the human world you're not familiar with?
霍夫曼：可你为什么仍然努力着将神秘学的知识置入自己并不熟稔的人类世界?

Marcus falls silent for a while, her previous blush turning into a cold sweat.
马库斯久久没能开口。

Her unspoken thoughts, aspirations as a writer, and her inner struggles ... It felt as though this Hofmann saw through them all.
那些未曾言明的心声，贯穿写作始终的愿望，无不清晰地落在霍夫曼的眼里。

Yet, feeling as though she had been spared the headman's axe for today at least, she raised her eyes upwards.
终于，她抬起头来。

Marcus: That's ... I suppose that's a valid question. Perhaps I am too naive ...
马库斯：您说得没错，或许这只是个幼稚的想法……

Marcus: For me, I've always seen the world as just a kind of puzzle book. Perplexing riddles, obscure words, and bewildering images ... One I was happy to keep at a distance. Even if it had many pleasant aspects ...
马库斯：对我而言，这个世界是一本太过复杂的书，它有数不清的谜团、晦涩难懂的语句与令我眼花缭乱的插图……可它同样有着许多有趣的部分……

Marcus: Human science, progressive ideologies, arcanists' sports, various newly discovered critters, and many, many more ...
马库斯：人类的科学，当下的进步思潮，神秘学家们的运动会，形态迥异的魔精们……

Marcus: I wanted to share those things, the pleasant ones, they deserve to be known by more people—whether humans or arcanists.
马库斯：它们理应被更多人知道——不论是人类，或是神秘学家。

Marcus: Her voice is trembling yet grows more resolute on each word.
马库斯：她的声音微微发颤，却又无比坚定。

Marcus: If I keep reading, I'll eventually find the answers to everything. I can introduce human arts and crafts to the arcanists, and demystify arcanist fables and legends for the humans ...
马库斯：只要我一直阅读下去，我就能从中找到所有问题的答案，能为神秘学家们介绍人类社会的艺术与出色的工艺，能向人类解释困扰他们的种种神秘传闻与传说……

Marcus: I'll be the bridge between humans and arcanists, helping them understand one another.
马库斯：能够令人类与神秘学家相互理解，甚至能……成为两个种族之间的桥梁。

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: Oh dear ... D-Did I say that all out loud ...?
马库斯：天、天呐……我、我竟然说了……把什么都说出来了……

Marcus: She awkwardly gasps trying to take in a great puff of the fresh sea air, her face flushing red from ear to ear.
马库斯：她的脸颊涨得通红，大口地汲取着新鲜的、裹着湿润海风的空气。

Still, a gentle but intentional clap of applause follows.
略显突兀的掌声轻轻响起。

Hofmann: That is a great aspiration, Ms. Marcus.
霍夫曼：马库斯小姐，这是个伟大的理想。

Hofmann: The Foundation has been working toward the very same goal.
霍夫曼：基金会同样在为之努力。

Marcus: Thank you for your kind words, Madam Hofmann ...
马库斯：谢谢您的鼓励，霍夫曼女士……

Yet, the "catastrophe" flashes through her mind once more, plunging her back into cold reality.
先前的种种事故走马灯般地浮现在她的脑海，冷酷地敲打着她。

Marcus: Only, it seems my writing has done nothing but push me further from my goal ... Not only have I failed to demystify arcanum, I failed my publisher's expectation and my readers ...
马库斯：事实上，我的写作反倒令它们离我越来越远了……我不仅没有向读者们普及神秘学知识，还连累了出版社……

Marcus: I couldn't even write a serviceable story ...
马库斯：我甚至连最基本的故事都没有写好……

Hofmann: Ah, do you mean this edition?
霍夫曼：你说的是这一篇吗?

Hofmann produces a folded magazine. The images of the Flannan Isles on it coldly clutch at Marcus's heart.
霍夫曼掏出了一份折了几折的报纸，弗兰南群岛的照片像是幽灵般缠上了马库斯。

Marcus: Y-You didn't throw it away ...?
马库斯：您……您居然还留着它……

Hofmann: You underestimate yourself, Ms. Marcus. The story isn't as hopeless as you think.
霍夫曼：你低估了自己，马库斯小姐。这并非一个无可救药的故事。

Marcus: ... I don't quite understand what you mean.
马库斯：……我不太明白您的意思。

Her breath quickens.
她的呼吸急促了起来。

Marcus: Madam Hofmann, a-are you saying that I might still be able to turn this story around?
马库斯：霍夫曼女士，难道您能拯救它吗……?!

Hofmann: Humans often read things differently from arcanists. What arcanists consider perspicuous may, on the contrary, read as unfathomable to humans.
霍夫曼：人类的阅读习惯并不同于神秘学家。那些神秘学家们视作理所当然的细枝末节，恰恰是人类所无法理解的。

Hofmann: Compared to the wild, divergent way of thinking of arcanists, humans are more inclined toward concrete conclusions backed by hard evidence.
霍夫曼：相比于依托灵感的肆意发散，我们更倾向于确凿的结论。

Hofmann: After arriving here, I quickly grasped the gap in thinking between yourself and the human readers of History of the Flannan Isles.
霍夫曼：当我抵达岛上后，我理解了《弗兰南群岛史》的作者与读者们在思维上的隔阂。

Hofmann: To begin with, just how many people do you think are aware of the existence of ghosts?
霍夫曼：你认为有多少人了解幽灵的存在?

Marcus stops in place as she goes over Hofmann's unexpectedly stunning question.
认真做着笔记的手停下了，它在纸上无意识地轻点。

Marcus: Well, I understand the story of the Brown Lady of Raynham Hall is widespread. Many people have tried to find her ... Meanwhile, the ghosts of the Graham Mansion are probably only known to the Scottish people ...
马库斯：布朗克尔公爵夫人的故事流传很广，应该有不少人试图找到她……格拉姆夫庄园的故事就要小众一些了，也许只有苏格兰的人们听说过……

Marcus: The White Lady is quite famous in Germany, but people mostly tell her stories to scare children ...
马库斯：白女士的故事在德国相当有名，但它大多被用在恐吓孩子的话术里……

Hofmann: Ah, so now you see it, don't you, Ms. Marcus?
霍夫曼：很好，马库斯小姐。你理解了这一点。

Hofmann: History of the Flannan Isles is published in the Daydream Post historical column. For most of its audience, the existence of ghosts is beyond far-fetched.
霍夫曼：《弗兰南群岛史》刊登于《白日梦邮报》的历史版面。对它的大部分受众而言，他们并不能轻易理解幽灵的存在。

Hofmann: For you to adapt the stories of three ghosts, without ever taking the time to explain the ghosts themselves to your readers. Well, is it any wonder so many doubted you?
霍夫曼：你采用了三位幽灵的故事，却从未向读者们解释过它们。

Hofmann: Your readers couldn't see and understand your ghost friends as you do. Nor could they have realized these ghosts were nearly as equally about the truths of the Flannan Isles as anyone else.
霍夫曼：读者们看不见你的幽灵朋友，不明白幽灵先生们绝不是无所不能，不理解他们不过是如我们一般的普通人，同样茫然于弗兰南群岛的真相。

Hofmann: The readers followed the ghosts throughout the story, but never got to know them. They also couldn't fully understand the parts on arcanum. The readers didn't feel engaged.
霍夫曼：人们只能跟随这些脚不着地的幽灵们窜上窜下，却从没有一次真正追上过他们。那些属于神秘学的故事如泡沫般在他们眼前破碎，却令他们浑然不觉，一无所获。

Hofmann puts away the magazine.
霍夫曼收起了报纸。

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: You're right ... I kept saying that I wanted humans and arcanists to understand one another, that I wanted to bring readers a more profound experience, but in doing so, I overlooked the obvious ...
马库斯：您是对的……我口口声声说着要让人类与神秘学家互相理解，盼望着能给读者带来更深层的体验，却疏漏了如此简单的问题……

Marcus: H-How did I let this happen ...
马库斯：这、这实在是……

Marcus: A strong sense of regret surges up to her throat involuntarily.
马库斯：懊悔从脚尖开始翻涌，逐渐涨了上来，几乎要将她吞没。

Hofmann: Humans are often unable to sense the subtle folds in emotions. They're confined by their rational senses. On the other hand, arcanists can just as easily be trapped by their emotions, overlooking the obvious, as you say. So ...
霍夫曼：人类囿于理性的思维定式，难以触及情绪中细微的褶皱。但这同样困住了神秘学家，他们为情绪所俘获，却往往忽略最浅显的信息。

Hofmann: Don't blame yourself for this.
霍夫曼：这并非你个人的缺陷。

A touch of warmth reaches Marcus's shoulder.
一阵温和的触感抵达了肩头。

Marcus lifts her head blankly, not yet realizing that Hofmann picked up her pen from the ground.
马库斯茫然地抬起头来，那支掉在地上的笔不知何时已到了对方的手中。

Hofmann: As an arcanist, you can "read" the intricacies of the world that others would easily miss, but that is also the problem.
霍夫曼：你能够心无旁骛地沉浸在阅读的世界，轻易地了解他人所忽略的一切。它来自你的天赋，也成了这个故事的症结。

Hofmann: Human readers are more used to sifting through clues and details to make logical sense of the story. They also like to simplify things and draw a single conclusion.
霍夫曼：而你的读者则更擅于捕捉线索，将其置入故事，置入至高的逻辑王国，以使繁复的归于简洁，使抽象的归于具象，使所有的谜都能得到唯一的结论。

Hofmann: If you would permit me to offer some editorial advice for your History of the Flannan Isles, I have a suggestion.
霍夫曼：针对《弗兰南群岛史》目前的内容，我有一些修改建议。

Marcus: P-Please tell me.
马库斯：可……我该怎么做呢?

Hofmann: You need to find some answers of your own.
霍夫曼：你需要找到关乎自己的答案。

Marcus: Conclusions ... of my own?
马库斯：答案……?

Hofmann: I think, you yourself do not yet know all the mysteries of the Flannan Isles? But do you believe you can unravel all the truths about this place?
霍夫曼：你是否全然理解了弗兰南群岛的一切？你能够解开关于这座岛的全部真相吗?

Marcus: No ... I-I don't think I can ...
马库斯：我……我做不到……

Marcus: Perhaps ... creating this column was a mistake, after all?
马库斯：难道……我从一开始便不应该写下这篇专栏吗……?

Hofmann: No, Ms. Marcus. Not knowing the truth is nothing at all to be ashamed of.
霍夫曼：不，马库斯小姐。对真相一无所知并非什么不可原谅的罪行。

Hofmann: Rationality drives us to understand reality as we see it. Curiosity aids us in searching for the puzzles yet to be solved. Both of them must be the fuels that power your writing.
霍夫曼：理性推动着我们记录所见的真实，好奇心则帮助我们写下尚未了然的谜团，而两者都能成为写作的燃料。

Marcus: I thought a writer should be absolutely certain about everything they write ...
马库斯：我以为我们笔下的一切，都应该都是确信的……

Marcus: If my readers want conclusions, how could they accept that there are puzzles that even I cannot solve ...?
马库斯：……没有真相的谜团，读者们会接受吗?

Hofmann: I think they will. If you offer them the chance.
霍夫曼：我想会的。

Hofmann: They will understand your confusion and curiosity, as well as your passion for trying to unravel these mysteries.
霍夫曼：读者们能够理解你的迷茫与好奇，理解你希望揭开谜团的热情。

Hofmann: Whether you find the truth or not, it is the journey that keeps us engaged. What they need is an exhilarating experience from the perspective of an arcanist.
霍夫曼：他们因此发觉一种来自神秘学家的新奇视角，收获一段足够引人入胜的经历。

Marcus: Spark their curiosity with puzzles I've still left unsolved ... Do you think my story could really do that?
马库斯：以一个未解的谜来吸引读者，启发读者的好奇心……我的故事能做到吗?

Marcus: Can I really inspire them to seek the truth themselves ...?
马库斯：我能鼓动他们……去寻找真相吗?

Hofmann: Perhaps. To seek the truth is a long journey, but still ...
霍夫曼：也许，这会是段漫长的旅程。但无论如何……

Hofmann: When we bravely admit that truth doesn't always exist, we find another truth. And this courage deserves respect.
霍夫曼：坦然承认“一段缺乏真相的现实”，本就是一种可敬的真相。

The sun isn't any brighter than usual, nestled under the blanket of cloudy sea air.
当天的太阳并不比往常的任何一天更明亮。

But its dazzling warmth still seems to scorch her for the first time in a long time.
但那股温暖与刺目却真实地灼痛了她。

Marcus: Madam Hofmann didn't stay long.
马库斯：霍夫曼女士并未在这儿停留太久。

Marcus: But she left behind a journal filled with her comments and suggestions, and an address as concise as she was.
马库斯：她留下了那张写满了批注与建议的报纸，以及一个如她一样简洁的地址。

Marcus: To a nameless small island near the Flannan Isles, where Madam Hofmann said she will continue her work for a few weeks before returning to the Foundation.
马库斯：我记住了它，一座位于弗兰南群岛旁的无名小岛。霍夫曼女士会在那儿继续她的工作，也许会在几周后彻底离开这儿。

Marcus: She also spoke with me about joining the Foundation before she left ...
马库斯：临走前，她又一次提到了基金会……我同样记了下来。

Marcus: But for the time being, I still felt I had more pressing matters to attend to.
马库斯：但眼下，我还有更重要的事需要完成。

Marcus: I picked up my pen and courage again to face up to my catastrophe and overcome it.
马库斯：我再次拿起了笔，重新面对这份糟糕的作品。

Marcus: I took Madam Hoffman's advice to heart. My writing was no longer crammed with every detail until I began to scribble in the margins and between the rows ...
马库斯：我不再全盘将我阅读到的故事与所有的细节都塞进那小小的方格纸中……

Marcus: This revision was, quite frankly, an extensive overhaul. The gentlemen ghosts voiced some over-eager protests despite my repeated apologies ...
马库斯：尽管向杜卡特先生、马歇尔先生、唐纳德先生表达了歉意，但我的删改仍然遭到了他们的不满与严正抗议……

Marcus: But Madam Hofmann's comments and suggestions instilled great courage in me.
马库斯：霍夫曼女士的批注给予了我巨大的勇气。

Marcus: And finally ...
马库斯：终于……

Marcus: I completed it.
马库斯：我完成了它。

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

颁奖辞
Award Speech CH17703-07

Award Speech
颁奖辞

The lighthouse illuminates its surroundings, faithful and steady as always. The waves lash against the rocky shore, and the three ghostly gentlemen are in the midst of a merry uproar.
灯塔忠实地朝着四周播洒光亮，海浪一丝不苟地冲洗着沿岸的礁石，闹作一团、其乐融融的幽灵先生们。

A soothing sea breeze brushes past Marcus, like a long-lost friend.
一阵海风久违地拂过了马库斯。

Everything before her is familiar yet surreal.
眼前的一切都令她熟悉而恍惚。

Marcus: So, gentlemen, have you stopped arguing ...?
马库斯：先生们，你们……不再争吵了吗?

Thomas: Look who's here, mates, and the lass a sight for dead eyes!
马歇尔：嘿，朋友们，瞧瞧谁来了——!

The three surround Marcus with a delicate kindness, as if encircling a flower that has finally bloomed.
三人迅速地将马库斯围在中间，像是簇拥着一束终于盛开的花。

Donald: We ... we thought you might not want to be friends with us after all our arguing ...
唐纳德：我……我还以为你不再愿意和我们当、当朋友了……

Marcus: No-no, I'm sorry ... It was only that it took a little extra time for me to prepare the new edition for my History of the Flannan Isles ...
马库斯：抱歉，先生们……整理新的几期《弗兰南群岛史》耗去的时间令我始料未及……

Marcus: But at last, I've finally completed my final draft and sent it along to Ms. Dennehy. Hopefully, I haven't made her wait too long as well.
马库斯：但我总算将这几期稿件都寄给了丹尼希女士，希望这没有让她等待太久。

A pair of transparent hands gently pat Marcus's shoulder.
一双略微透明的手轻拍了拍马库斯的肩膀。

James: We know what you've been through, lassie. Without your perseverance and talent, winning back those readers would have been impossible.
杜卡特：我们都能理解你，小马库斯。创作可不是件轻松的事，否则，你也没法重新赢回读者们的心……

James: And a spot more courage than a sailor betting the last of his pay in Monte Carlo!
杜卡特：这可比在蒙特卡罗一掷千金要有勇气得多!

James: But you did it, lass. Aye, and some fine work, if I do say so myself.
杜卡特：可你做到了，你取得了巨大的成功——!

Marcus: Stop it now, Captain, you're just flattering me ...
马库斯：杜卡特先生，您的话太夸张了……

She shrinks her neck with embarrassment.
马库斯紧张地缩了缩脖子。

Thomas: No, not at all, Ms. Marcus. It's just as the blowhard said, for once. You dinnae gone to collect the post yet, have you? Seems your edition made the papers already, and the postmen brought the replies.
马歇尔：我可以作证，老杜卡特说的半点儿也不夸张——噢，你一定没看最近的报纸，你的读者们又一次给你寄来了许多信！

Donald: And, and they're g-good letters this time ... N-Nothing terrible about them ... We checked!
唐纳德：但、但……这次，它们不可怕，它们很好……

Marcus opens one of the readers' letters.
一封封眼熟的信件又一次被递到了马库斯的手中。

Marcus: "I feel so honored to write you this letter, as a now humbled fan of your History of the Flannan Isles—oh, should I call it To the Archipelago now?"
马库斯：“很荣幸向您写下这样一封信，《弗兰南群岛史》、噢现在应该说是《到岛上来》的作者。”

Marcus: "Your courage is more than admirable. Who could have thought you'd be brave enough to make such an extensive revision ...?"
马库斯：“我敬佩您的勇气，敬佩您敢于对自己所认可的故事进行大刀阔斧地修改……”

Marcus: "Let me express my warmest congratulations, for now that I see your work for what it truly is, I am so pleased to have experienced such an unforgettable fantasy tale."
马库斯：“同样，我希望能向您表达祝贺。您写下了一个如此精彩的故事，尽管它的结局尚未发表，但它仍然在我心中留下难以忘怀的印象……”

Marcus: ... Fantasy?
马库斯：故事……？

Marcus: Suppressing her fleeting doubts, she continues reading the letter.
马库斯：她压下了短暂的疑惑，又接着读了下去。

Marcus: "Thanks to you and these ghost gentlemen you've invented, all of us following along get to experience a little piece of their world, just as you imagined it."
马库斯：“正因为有它们、有您的存在，我们才得以了解这令人陌生、而又充满惊喜与趣味的另一个世界。”

Marcus: "Yours faithfully, a reader eagerly awaiting the next edition."
马库斯：“——一位苦苦等待下一节的热切读者”。

Marcus: ...!
马库斯：……！

Marcus feels at once a sense of loss, something she tries to suppress rather than let it eat at her.
马库斯读完了信，小心翼翼地收起了不知从何而来的失落。

Donald: Th-There are a mess more of these letters ... oh, oh including one from the Daydream Post.
唐纳德：不、不止这些……《白日梦邮报》也、也给你写了信……

Donald: "Dear Ms. Marcus, we are more than delighted to share with you that, thanks to your newly updated To the Archipelago series, the Daydream Post has seen a tremendous rise in sales."
唐纳德：“尊敬的马库斯小姐，我们很高兴地向您宣布，因为您的《到岛上来》,《白日梦邮报》的销售额获得了巨大的成功。”

Donald: "What's more, we've even received requests to change the serialization schedule—they want at least two editions per week. After discussion, the publishing house has decided to provide you with an entire new section."
唐纳德：“读者们积极地向我们提议，他们希望能修改《到岛上来》的连载计划，建议我们每周出版两节以上的新内容。为此，出版社决定，为您的作品设立新的版面——”

Donald: "We call it, The Tall Lighthouse!"
唐纳德：“——《灯塔故事集》!”

Donald: "Our sincerest regards to you and your ghostly friends."
唐纳德：“向您与您的幽灵朋友们致以最诚挚的问候。”

Praise pours out from one letter after another, overwhelming Marcus's humility until she feels faint.
纷繁的褒赞之词从不同的信封中涌出，争先恐后地挤入了马库斯的眼中。

Staggering, she retreats into the sanctuary of her room.
她踉跄着退后，又缩回了那所小小的房间。

The excitement conveyed in the editor's letter still lingers as a vivid image in Marcus's mind, yet she remains more than a little perplexed.
来自于出版社编辑的热心提议始终映在她的脑海中。

Marcus: Did they choose to move To the Archipelago from the Documentary Literature section ...?
马库斯：《到岛上来》不再发表在“历史纪实”版面了吗……?

Unsure about the publisher's decision, she continues writing.
她难以理解其中的深意，只好继续写了下去。

As new manuscripts are sent out, enthusiastic readers' letters are delivered to the island one after another.
一页页新的稿纸寄出，一封封热情的信件寄回了这座岛。

Marcus: "This is what I call a perfect representation of literary fiction. The tale of this investigative columnist's friendship with these three ghosts brought tears to my eyes!"
马库斯：“一个完美的故事，调查员小姐与三位幽灵的友谊令人动容!”

Marcus: "To dive into this surreal world of mysteries has become a pastime of mine during each and every afternoon tea. Your creative writing has truly brought a smile to my face!"
马库斯：“令人望而兴叹的神秘世界，下午茶时间最好的消遣……感谢您，您编写的故事集慷慨地给予了我长达数个清晨的欢笑!”

Marcus: "I envy the talents of these comical ghosts, and your imaginative arcanist way of writing is, I must say, a refreshing break from the humdrum of human reporting. I look forward to reading more as soon as you can conjure it up ..."
马库斯：“幽灵们的天赋让我嫉妒，神秘学家们写作故事的角度同样令人耳目一新。我期待着您更多古灵精怪的想象……”

Marcus: "I personally believe this series deserves the title of Fantasy Story of the Year nominee. And if it doesn't meet the award criteria, we should create a new award for it, something like Arcanist Fiction of the Year!"
马库斯：“我个人认为，本作值得入选年度百篇幻想故事之一……如果不符合标准，我们应该为之开设新的神秘学主题故事奖!”

All these letters are brimming with effervescent praise, but all with the same monotonous implication.
它们百般溢美，却又千篇一律。

Marcus: I ...
马库斯：我……

Overwhelmed by the return of her anxiety, Marcus snaps her pen against the paper.
一种巨大的惶恐折断了这支笔。

Marcus: ...!
马库斯：……!

As she plunges yet deeper into the black fog, a familiar voice jolts her back to reality.
马库斯怔了怔神，耳边的讨论声又清晰了起来。

Thomas: Hullo, Ms. Marcus, something on your mind, lass?
马歇尔：嘿，马库斯，你在想什么呢?

Thomas: Seems like you've been out to sea with no paddle, a wee bit more than usual lately. Pining for a vacation, maybe? You're not turning into a ghost like us, are you?
马歇尔：你最近看起来都魂不守舍的，难道你也要变成像我们这样的幽灵了吗?

James: Balderdash! She's not pining for the fjords, nor has she passed on.
杜卡特：别胡说八道，臭小子——!

James: Our wee writer is only a trifle tired from all her hard work. As usual, you've no respect for matters of the mind.
杜卡特：我们的大作家一定是累了，像你这样的文学白痴怎么能理解进行伟大创作的艰难呢!

He casually strokes his mustache, taking pride in Marcus, and, by some extension, himself.
他随意地撇了撇自己的胡须，为马库斯，也为自己骄傲着。

James: Ms. Marcus! Dare I say, you've been a veritable star as late. Even I'm curious about what adventures I'll embark on next!
杜卡特：马库斯，你写得真不错！连我都开始好奇后面我会发生些什么冒险了——!

Donald: M-Marcus, do you think you'll keep writing ...? About this island, about us ...
唐纳德：马、马库斯，你会一直写下去吗？……写这座岛、写我们……

This question, innocent as it is, breaks the spell that had too long lingered over her, as if waking her up from a stupor.
突如其来的疑问惊醒了她。

Marcus: Will I ... keep writing?
马库斯：我……还会写下去吗?

Marcus: I hoped to garner more readers with elaborate stories that have more twists and turns. I hoped to make more humans understand and accept arcanists.
马库斯：我希望凭借情节更曲折、内容更丰富的故事吸引更多的读者，我希望越来越多的人能逐渐理解神秘学，接受神秘学家……

Marcus: I hoped that one day, humans and arcanists could set aside their differences and join hands to uncover the ultimate truth ...
马库斯：我希望有朝一日人们不分你我，能一同发掘最后的真相……

Marcus: I hoped to record and represent all the truths I've "read" to the readers. Even more so, I hoped I'd be able to explore the mysteries of the Flannan Isles with them.
马库斯：我希望能够记录真相，盼望着更多读者的注目，更希望能与他们一同探索弗兰南群岛的谜团……

Marcus: But ... what is it that they want?
马库斯：可……能令他们动容的究竟是什么呢?

Marcus: Convoluted mystery plots? Wild imaginations plucked straight from the realm of fantasy? An "everyone lived happily ever after" ending?
马库斯：是更曲折的情节、更惊奇的想象……还是更圆满的结局?

Marcus looks up in a daze, evading the expectant eyes around her.
马库斯恍惚地抬起头来，没去看周围满含期待的目光。

The sky above is unusually clear, but that doesn't seem to faze her.
天空万里无云，她什么也没有读出来。

Marcus: To the Archipelago has achieved significant success.
马库斯：《到岛上来》取得了重大的成功，这理应是件值得高兴的事。

Marcus: So, why can't I find joy in their praise ...?
马库斯：可，我却没能从这些褒奖中收获更多的喜悦……?

Marcus: The self-questioning abruptly stops. The obvious answer lingers, crawling back from her tongue.
马库斯：对自我的质问戛然而止，一个早已清晰的答案停在了嘴唇边。

Marcus: To the Archipelago is nothing but a well-crafted fiction, a broken puzzle.
马库斯：《到岛上来》成了一个构思精巧的虚构故事，成了一个虚无的谜题。

Marcus: The people reading it don't care about the truth, nor the real arcanum behind it.
马库斯：人们并不关心真相，也并不在乎真正的神秘学。

Marcus: So how could this be bringing me closer to my dream ...?
马库斯：凭借它，我便能靠近我的理想吗……?

Marcus: This series was inspired by the first-hand experiences of my dear friends. Without their memories, their stories, I could never have written these tall tales ...
马库斯：这个故事的素材来源于杜卡特先生、唐纳德先生与马歇尔先生的真实经历，如果没有他们的讲述，我不可能写出这样好的文章……

Marcus: Of course, I know my writing skills contributed a little to this unprecedented acclaim, but only so much ...
马库斯：写作本身就更称不上是我的功劳了……

Marcus: But it was Madam Hofmann and her invaluable comments that led to the changes that made To the Archipelago a success.
马库斯：霍夫曼女士为我提供了帮助，她所教授的技巧促使《到岛上来》的改变，也使它收获了远超以往的正面评价……

Marcus: I can't take an ounce of credit for all of these.
马库斯：它们都与我无关。

Marcus: Even if I were to explore every inch of the archipelago and unravel all its mysteries ...
马库斯：即使有一天，我穷尽了岛上的每一个角落，解释了其中所有的谜团。

Marcus: The readers might only see it as the inevitable conclusion to an entertaining fantasy.
马库斯：对读者来说，这也不过是一个精彩的故事终于迎来了理所当然的结尾。

Marcus: ... Is the answer to my dreams something I can find in this small archipelago?
马库斯：……如此渺小的弗兰南群岛，能称作是我理想的全部么?

The whistle seems to faintly echo in Marcus's mind.
微不可闻的话语在马库斯的脑海里回荡，好似永无止息。

The steam whistle grows louder, overwhelming her eardrums with its piercing cry.
它们愈发响亮，几乎要震破耳膜。

Like a sound emerging from the depths of her heart, a distant call from a grander stage.
像是从内心深处生出的鸣响，像是来自更大舞台的遥遥呼唤。

Marcus: That's ... a steam whistle. A ship!
马库斯：汽笛声……

Marcus: ... Madam Hofmann!
马库斯：——霍夫曼女士!

The whistle continues to sound nearby as a sail of a familiar checkered pattern is raised.
不远处的汽笛声仍然鸣响着，灰白的帆不紧不慢地升了起来。

Marcus: The final draft is in my room, James. Would you please send it to the care of Ms. Dennehy for me? I entrust this mission to you, Captain! Thanks!
马库斯：终稿在我的房间里，请帮我把它寄给丹尼希女士。拜托您了，杜卡特先生！

She runs toward Hofmann without looking back, leaving her puzzled phantom friends behind.
她头也不回地向海岸跑去，友人们疑惑的呼唤被远远地甩在了后面。

James: Ms. Marcus, you're off at a steam! But, aye ... well, just where are you off to now?
杜卡特：嘿，小马库斯、未来的写作之星，咱们的好朋友，你这是要去哪——?!

Marcus: Farewell, Captain James ... Farewell, Donald ... Farewell, Thomas!
马库斯：再见，杜卡特先生……再见，唐纳德先生……再见，马歇尔先生！

The trapped young lady finally takes a leap forward.
困于岛上的姑娘终于迈开了步子。

She does not look back.
她不再回头。

Carried by the sea wind, the letters and manuscripts flutter in the air as if waving Marcus farewell.
那些信封和稿纸一同飞扬起来，像是在挥手送别。

Marcus: Please wait, Madam Hofmann!
马库斯：请、请等等我，霍夫曼女士——！

The Foundation's ship begins to loom larger in Marcus's view. The surprised figure aboard becomes clear to see.
眼前的船变得越发庞大，连同着那抹略显讶异的灰白身影也越发清晰。

Hofmann: ...!
霍夫曼：……！

Marcus: Madam Hofmann, I want to join the Foundation!
马库斯：霍夫曼女士，我要加入基金会！

Marcus: That was probably the first decision I ever really made on my own.
马库斯：或许，这是我第一次做出属于自己的决定。

Marcus: But why ...? Why did it suddenly come to my mind?
马库斯：可为什么……我会突然想起来它呢?

Marcus: I-It was a long time ago ...
马库斯：这明明、是很久以前的事了……

As her vision clears, the overturned chairs and collapsed curtains around her hint at the ultimate conclusion of the current play.
视线逐渐清晰，翻倒的座椅、倾覆的幕布暗示着眼下故事的真正结局。

Marcus: ... Why did I choose that path then?
马库斯：……我当时为什么要那么做呢?

Marcus: What have I really achieved?
马库斯：我……究竟又为什么要来到这儿呢?

TO BE CONTINUED...
TO BE CONTINUED…

小小调查员
The Young Investigator CH17703-08

The Young Investigator
小小调查员

Marcus is like a book swept out to sea, floating directionless through the dead of night.
一本微茫的书在无边无际的黑夜中漂流着。

Familiar pages flash rapidly through her mind.
过往的每一页在马库斯的脑海中迅速掠过。

Echoes of the past ringing yet again in the present.
如在昨日，如在眼前。

Marcus: I remember now ... I wanted to make a choice of my own ...
马库斯：我想起来了……我希望能做出一个属于自己的选择……

Marcus: So I joined the Foundation. I learned of the "Storm." I bade farewell to my era ... and my old dream ...
马库斯：为此，我加入了基金会……我知道了“暴雨”……我告别了我的时代……我的理想……

Marcus: A choice of my own ... But did I really make one at all?
马库斯：我……做出了吗?

A sudden agony almost tears the entire book apart.
突如其来的剧痛几乎要把整本书都撕裂开来。

The spine of the book trembles as it struggles to turn a new page.
书脊颤抖着揭开新的一页。

Marcus: Yes, I made my choice. Now see where it's led me. I've ruined everything.
马库斯：是的，我做到了。可我的选择……几乎摧毁了所有人的努力。

Marcus: Lady Isolde held a grand exhibition where she made that speech ...
马库斯：伊索尔德女士举办了一场盛大的沙龙演说，在那儿，她发表了……

Isolde: I wish for the arcanists to unite ...
伊索尔德：我希望，我们神秘学家能够联合起来……

Isolde: And establish an independent kingdom of freedom, free from repression and oppression!
伊索尔德：——建立一个不再有压抑的、自由的、属于我们自己的独立王国！

Marcus: It's all my fault ... If only I hadn't violated the confidentiality agreement, she wouldn't have made that dangerous speech.
马库斯：这全是我的错……如果我没有违反保密条例，这场叛国演讲也不会发生……

Marcus: What I did not only failed to help the arcanists, but worse still it intensified the divide between us and humans.
马库斯：我的努力非但没有帮到任何一位神秘学家，甚至加重了他们与人类之间的隔阂。

Marcus: Lady Isolde—and many other innocent arcanists deceived by Manus Vindictae—shouldn't have fallen into such a predicament ...
马库斯：重塑蒙蔽了伊索尔德女士，还有许多无辜的神秘学家……他们本不应陷入如此困境……

Marcus: Political assassinations, ethnic conflicts, and civil turmoil have erupted all over the world ... History has been altered; the "Storm" was formed.
马库斯：政治刺杀、民族冲突、城市混乱……历史发生了震荡，暴雨发生了……

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Marcus: I shouldn't have—I should never have called out to Madam Hofmann that day ... I should have stayed on the Flannan Isles!
马库斯：不、不！也许我从一开始就不应该叫住霍夫曼女士……我应该一直留在弗兰南群岛！

Marcus: ... Madam Hofmann?
马库斯：霍夫曼……女士?

Then comes a clearer, more suffocating page.
而后是更清晰，令人更难以喘息的一页。

Marcus: No! Madam Hofmann!!!
马库斯：霍夫曼女士——！

Hofmann: *coughs weakly* Don't cry, Marcus. I know what I'm doing.
霍夫曼：咳……马库斯，不要落泪。我知道自己在做什么。

Hofmann: The future ... is yours.
霍夫曼：未来是……你们的时代。

Marcus: No!
马库斯：不——！

This page seems agonizingly long.
这是无比漫长的一页。

Marcus: What have I really achieved?
马库斯：唔——！我究竟做到了什么呢……?

Images bristling with pain and regret ruthlessly intertwine in Marcus's frantic thoughts.
无数的画面在混乱的意识中交织着，漫长的痛苦与遗憾挤占着马库斯的意识。

Marcus: Back on the island, I couldn't even stop my friends from fighting. How could I have thought I would be the one to change humanity's discrimination towards arcanists ...
马库斯：在岛上，我没能阻止朋友们的争吵，没能改变人类对于神秘学家的偏见，没能解决任何一场争端……

Marcus: After I made just that one choice, to join the Foundation, every choice afterward only seemed to magnify the number of people I hurt, even Madam Hofmann ...
马库斯：而当我踏入基金会，我的选择迫使更多人受到了伤害，就连霍夫曼女士也因我而死……

Marcus: I never once managed to live up to my aspiration ...
马库斯：我一次都没能践行自我的理想……

Marcus: C-Could it be that I ...
马库斯：难道、难道我——

The cold abyss stretches out before her. Reality, naked of any illusions.
一个冰冷而令人绝望的现实耸立在她的面前。

Marcus: I've never left the Flannan Isles.
马库斯：……我从来都没有离开过弗兰南群岛。

The active cells within her body finally find an outlet amidst the surging pain.
活跃的细胞在汹涌的痛苦中终于找到了出口。

A strange scent invades the air, blurring Marcus's vision.
在一阵古怪的香气中，马库斯的视野愈发模糊。

"Donald": M-Ms. Marcus, how did you end up here?
“唐纳德”：马……马库斯，你怎么会在这儿?

"James": Oh, poor lassie, you look miserable ... What sort of trouble have you been in?
“杜卡特”：噢，可怜的小马库斯，你看上去真狼狈……你遇到什么不好的事了吗?

"Thomas": Dinnae worry, mate. We've always been here for you, always ready to lend you a hand!
“马歇尔”： 别担心，我的朋友，我们一直在这儿，我们会帮你！

The phantoms, as ever before, gather around her with great enthusiasm.
幽灵们一如既往地凑在她的跟前，热情地手舞足蹈。

Marcus: James ... Donald ... Thomas ...
马库斯： 杜卡特先生……唐纳德先生……马歇尔先生……

Marcus: I ...
马库斯： 我……

Her long-suppressed emotions finally breach their confines, finding a soothing haven on the windless island.
情绪终于决堤，在这片无风的岛屿中找到了得以喘息的港口。

Marcus: Aren't you disappointed in me ...?
马库斯： 你们不对我失望吗……?

Marcus: On the Flannan Isles, I tried to tell your story, but everyone only saw it as fiction. They praised its plot and suspense ... But none of the credit really belonged to me.
马库斯： 在弗兰南群岛，我试图写下对于历史的纪实，可人们将它视作故事，夸赞它的情节、它的悬念……可这些连半点都不属于我。

Marcus: I failed to unravel the mysteries, and I failed to help people understand arcanum. My so-called dream ... was nothing more than an excuse to run from reality.
马库斯： 我没能解开岛上的谜团，没能让更多人理解神秘学……我所谓的理想，只是一个用来逃避的借口……

Marcus: I had run, tail tucked, to the Foundation, and then to Vienna ...
马库斯： 我逃到了基金会，逃到了维也纳……

Marcus: In the end, it feels as though I've accomplished nothing.
马库斯： ……可我仍然一事无成。

Marcus: I couldn't help Madam Hofmann stop Manus Vindictae. I couldn't find the incantation that might grant immunity from the "Storm" ...
马库斯： 我没能帮上霍夫曼女士的忙，没能阻止重塑，没能找到免疫“暴雨”的术式……

Marcus: I only ruin everything!
马库斯： 我几乎搞砸了一切——！

Yet the bitter chill of remorse fails to tear her down ...
脱口而出的懊恼并没有如期地碎裂在地。

For her loyal friends' warmth, even through the veil of death, can illuminate the darkest nights. Like a refuge on her dark seas.
几双近乎透明的手接住了它。

"James": Lass, we don't know what kind of trouble you're facing now, but things are rarely as bad as you fear them to be. Take that on aged wisdom.
“杜卡特”： 不，小马库斯。尽管不知道你究竟遇上了什么，但事实并没有你想象得那么糟糕。

"Donald": Aye, I'm—no, we're all proud of you!
“唐纳德”： 我……我们都为你骄傲！

Marcus: But ... I didn't do anything helpful for you ...
马库斯： 但是，我什么也没帮上你们……

"Thomas": Right, now I won't have you slandering a friend of mine like that, eh? Or did you forget who wrote those wonderful stories what made people remember the Flannan Isles–and us–forever?
“马歇尔”：你怎么会这么想呢？我的朋友！——你为我们写出了一个精彩的故事，让人们永远地记住了弗兰南群岛，也记住了我们。

"James": That may well have been the cleverest thing I've heard you say yet.
“杜卡特”：是的，你帮了我们许多忙，是我们的英雄。

Marcus: But I didn't even uncover the truth behind your deaths. I've failed you all ...
马库斯：可我连你们死亡的真相都没能找到，我辜负了你们的期待……

Her head hangs low, with an irrepressible shake lurching her forward and back.
她的头埋得很低，肩膀不住地颤抖。

"James": Heh heh ...
“杜卡特”：呵呵……

A familiar touch of warmth reaches Marcus's shoulder again.
某种熟悉的温和触感又一次抵达了肩头。

"James": Now don't be so hard on yourself, lass. How can we blame you if we haven't figured that out for ourselves! With a dozen years head start no less!
“杜卡特”：别苛责自己，小马库斯。就连我们也没能找到自己变成这样的原因呢～

"James": We've always stayed here all this time, but we've never given up hope. We'll continue to seek out the truth, no matter how long it takes!
“杜卡特”：——可正因如此，我们始终留在这儿，始终奋不顾身地努力着。

"James": Remember what Madam Hoffman told you, "Whether you find the truth or not, it is the journey that keeps us engaged."
“杜卡特”：能够坦然面对“一段缺乏真相的现实”，清晰地理解这一点，却仍愿意向前迈步的人们，不是更加可敬么？

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

Suddenly, she is reminded of that edition.
恍然中，她又想起了那篇故事。

Why was it so loved by her readers?
它何以成功，又何以受无数人喜爱？

"James": ... You remember those letters from your readers?
“杜卡特”：……你还记得那些读者来信吗？

"James": So many bright ideas, trying to fix the puzzle you set out for them. Nary a one got close, eh? But, remember the fun we had talking them over?
“杜卡特”：他们的结论千奇百怪，逻辑也满是漏洞……可我们仍然乐此不疲地讨论着。

"James": Finding the answer is not what really matters, lass. What matters most is our perseverance —our courage to carry on.
“杜卡特”：——最重要的从来都不是尘埃落地的唯一的解，而是我们为真相一路追寻的心。

Marcus: ...!
马库斯：……！

Marcus finally lifts her head.
马库斯终于抬起头来。

Marcus: Madam Hofmann ... She understood that lesson all along and tried to pass it on to me.
马库斯：霍夫曼女士……她自始至终都明白这一点，也试图将它教导给我。

Marcus: ... But do I really understand it now?
马库斯：……我领会了吗?

Marcus: If I were to die today, would I know what I was supposed to do?
马库斯：如果我将在今天死去，我会明白自己应该做什么吗?

Marcus: I think ... I do now.
马库斯：我想，我明白了。

Standing up, she races forward, just like she did on the island coast that fateful day.
她站起身来，一如当时朝着海岸踏出的那一步。

Marcus: "What really scared me was not death, but the possibility of dying ignorant."
马库斯：我并不畏惧死亡，我害怕的是一无所知地死去。

Donald: Marcus, d-did you hear that? It's s-some kind of strange noise ...
唐纳德：马库斯，你、你听到了什么奇怪的声音吗?

Marcus: ...
马库斯：……

She takes a deep breath and opens her eyes.
她深呼吸了一口气，猛然睁开了眼睛。

Marcus: We ... we can still make this right.
马库斯：我……我们还能挽回这一切。

Marcus: Doctor, wait! There might be another way!
马库斯：等一下，医生！我想到了一个可能性——!

THE END
THE END